

11 rescued, 1 critical after factory blast in Mukundpur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Eleven people were rescued, and one person was critically injured after a single-storey utensil colouring factory collapsed because of an LPG cylinder explosion in north Delhi's Mukundpur area on Tuesday morning.

The incident occurred at Gali number 1, Ishu Vihar, Mukundpur-II, near the cremation ground.

At 9:37 am, Delhi Fire Services (DFS) got a call about a blast and a house collapse. The caller said several people might be trapped under the debris.

A DFS official said, "We received information about the blast and building col-

lapse, and it seemed people were trapped inside. Rescue teams were sent right away and started search and rescue operations as soon as they arrived."

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Outernorth) Hareshwar Swami said police learned about the blast and collapse around 9:30 am. An Emergency Response Vehicle on patrol and local police rushed to the scene right after getting the alert.

Swami said, "Eleven people have been rescued, including one woman in critical condition due to burn injuries. She was referred to Safdarjung Hospital."

The officer said the initial investigation showed the blast occurred while gas was being



Rescue operation is underway after a single-storey house collapsed following an LPG cylinder blast in Mukundpur on Tuesday

PANKAJ KUMAR

transferred from a large cylinder to a smaller one. Some cylinders were found at the site.

Swami said the building was a utensil colouring factory, and gas was being transferred between cylinders at the time, which likely caused the blast.

DFS officials said the ground floor was reportedly used to refill small LPG cylinders from commercial ones, which led to the collapse during the blast.

Swami reiterated that the building housed a factory for colouring utensils.

The blast occurred in a 250-square-yard single-storey house, officials said.

DFS said ten of the injured were taken to Babu Jagjivan Ram Memorial Hospital and Dr

Baba Saheb Ambedkar Hospital for treatment. The woman who was critically injured was sent to Safdarjung Hospital.

Authorities cleared the rubble and searched the collapsed building to make sure no one was still trapped.

Personnel from the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), Delhi Fire Services, local police, and a dog squad were deployed after the initial rescue operations. The DCP confirmed that all the injured were factory workers. An eyewitness said, "The moment I heard a loud blast-like sound, the first thing that came to my mind was that a gas cylinder had exploded. We immediately ran towards the spot and found that a house had col-

lapsed," he said. He said there was dust everywhere and people were shouting for help. Some people started recording videos on their phones.

"I personally requested them to stop filming and join the rescue effort because every second was important," he said. The eyewitness said about six people started clearing the debris using whatever tools they could find.

"By God's grace, we managed to pull out one person from under the rubble. They were frightened and injured," he added.

Another eyewitness, who was working nearby at the time of the incident, said he, too, rushed to the scene after hearing a loud explosion.

MCD releases report in Saket building collapse

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Three days after a four-storey building collapsed in Delhi's Said-ul-Ajaib area on the evening of May 30, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi on Tuesday released a detailed account of its response operations. The report confirmed that six people died, 13 were injured, and rescue and debris removal work had been continuing uninterrupted for over 42 hours, with 80 to 90 truckloads of debris cleared from the site so far.

The collapse was first reported at approximately 7:55 pm on May 30, when the MCD's Zonal Control Room received a telephonic alert. The corporation dispatched its Junior Engineer, Assistant Engineer, and other staff to the location along with JCBs, trucks, and machinery. Teams reached the site by around 8:30 pm. However, Delhi Police had cordoned off the area, and MCD officials were not permitted to enter until



approximately 10:30 pm.

The building, located at Khasra number 262, Gali number 5, Western Marg, Said-ul-Ajaib, covered an area of approximately 300 square metres.

The basement, ground floor, first floor, and second floor were constructed approximately 12 to 13 years ago. The third and fourth floors were added in recent years. The building stands in an unauthorised colony, not among the 1,511 colonies identified for regularisation.

Rescue operations began immediately after the collapse, led by teams from the National Disaster Response Force and the Delhi Fire Service. Sniffer dogs were

deployed. Out of the approximately 24 persons traced at the site, 18 were rescued safely.

Thirteen injured persons were shifted to a nearby trauma centre. Six people were confirmed dead.

After MCD teams gained access at 10:30 pm, they joined the NDRF and continued operations through the night and into June 1. The equipment deployed included three JCBs, two Poclair machines, three Hydra cranes, gas cutters, pneumatic hammers, scaffolding material, jacks, and girders. Precautionary measures were taken to secure the buildings adjacent to the collapsed structure, and local residents were directed to maintain a safe distance.

St Stephen's College schedules installation ceremony for principal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

St Stephen's College has scheduled the commissioning and installation service of its newly appointed principal, Susan Elias, for Wednesday morning at the college chapel. The ceremony is scheduled two days after she assumed charge, signalling that the institution is pressing ahead with the transition despite an unresolved dispute with Delhi University over alleged non-compliance with UGC regulations in the appointment process.

According to an official notice issued by the college on Tuesday and signed by college chaplain Revd Samuel John Shekhar, the installation service will be held at 8 am on Wednesday. The ceremony will be presided over by the Chairman of the college, Rt Rev Paul Swarup, followed by high tea at the library lawns.



The notice, addressed to senior and junior members of the faculty and non-teaching staff, described the event as the "Commissioning and Installation Service of Prof Susan Elias as the XIV Principal of St Stephen's College." It added that all members of the college community, including contractual and outsourced staff, are invited to the high tea.

Meanwhile, DU Registrar

Vikas Gupta confirmed on Tuesday that the university had already written to the UGC and was awaiting further directions on the matter.

Elias assumed charge as principal on Monday, becoming the 14th principal of the college and the first woman to hold the post in the institution's 145-year history since its founding in 1881. She succeeds former principal John Varghese.

LG approves reconstitution of Delhi Ridge Management Board

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a major administrative push to secure the National Capital's green lungs, Delhi Lieutenant Governor TS Sandhu has approved the reconstitution and notification of the Delhi Ridge Management Board (DRMB). This statutory overhaul, in pursuance of the Supreme Court's judgment in TN Godavarman Thirumulpad versus Union of India and others, and anchored in Section 3 of the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986, will lead to transitioning the Capital's ridge governance through an integrated, multi-agency regulatory body, a Lok Niwas statement said on Tuesday.

The Ridge represents ancient remnants of the Aravali range in the national Capital, which contribute prominently to the city's green cover.

The primary mandate of



LG TS Sandhu

the reconstituted Board focuses on absolute ecological balance, climate resilience, and safeguarding Delhi's vital ridge ecosystem through a robust combination of senior secretariat leadership and prominent environmental experts.

It may be noted that while the Ridge in Delhi is owned by the Delhi Development Authority, the E&F Department, GNCTD, is responsible for its maintenance and the MCD, NDMC, Revenue Department and Delhi Police are entrusted with the responsibility of enforcement for its protection.

Delhi plans major water overhaul to tackle shortages

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has launched what it describes as one of the biggest reforms of the Capital's water distribution system in decades, with a focus on fixing unequal supply, replacing ageing pipelines, and reducing massive losses of treated water across the city.

Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Tuesday announced a series of measures aimed at improving water management at a time when Delhi is facing rising demand and shrinking available resources during the summer season.

According to the Government, Delhi currently requires nearly 1,250 million gallons of water daily during peak summer months. However, reduced flow in the Yamuna following a prolonged dry spell has lowered water production by nearly 100 million gallons per day in recent days, affecting

supply in several areas.

Amid growing complaints of water shortages, the Government said it will begin a "Water Rationalisation Project" to correct long-standing imbalances in supply across the city. The Minister said complaints related to water scarcity continue to emerge every summer from nearly 12 to 13 Assembly constituencies, while some localities receive comparatively higher supply. The new project will study population density, demand patterns, existing infrastructure, and consumption levels to create a more balanced distribution network. He said the objective was to ensure that no locality remains underserved while other areas continue to receive excess supply.

The Government also announced a major infrastructure upgrade programme to replace old pipelines that are contributing to leakages and contamination. Officials said Delhi



Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh

has a water distribution network of nearly 16,634 kilometres, out of which around 5,500 kilometres of pipelines are more than 30 years old. These ageing pipelines are blamed for a significant loss of treated water before it reaches households.

Parvesh Sahib Singh said years of delayed investment in infrastructure had worsened the problem and that pipeline replacement work would now be taken up on priority.

Another major proposal under consideration is the conversion of the open DSB canal system into a closed pipeline network. According to the Minister, nearly 40 to 45 per cent of water is currently lost through the canal system.

He said IIT Roorkee has been asked to conduct a feasibility study for the project. The Government believes shifting to a pipeline-based system could significantly reduce wastage and improve efficiency.

CM pulls up officials over poor facilities at Burari DTO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday reprimanded Transport Department officials during a surprise inspection of transport facilities in Burari after finding long queues, inadequate seating, and poor public amenities at the District Transport Office.

The Chief Minister directed officials to immediately improve facilities for visitors and ordered that no citizen should be forced to wait outside Government offices in extreme heat without basic arrangements. She instructed authorities to create proper waiting areas with seating, clean drinking water, fans, coolers, and hygienic toilets for applicants visiting the office.

During the inspection, the Chief Minister interacted with people who had come for driving licence tests and other transport-related services. Several visitors complained about long wait times outside



the DTO building and the lack of drinking water and seating. Taking the complaints seriously, the Chief Minister rebuked officials and security staff on the spot.

She said citizens visiting Government offices deserve respectful treatment and proper facilities. Government buildings, she added, must function as citizen-friendly service centres rather than spaces that create inconvenience for the public.

The Chief Minister carried out a detailed inspection of multiple Transport Department facilities, includ-

ing the under-construction Automated Testing Station, the Vehicle Inspection Unit, and the Heavy Motor Vehicle Training Institute.

At the upcoming Automated Testing Station, officials informed her that the facility would be able to inspect five vehicles simultaneously and conduct fitness tests for nearly 80,000 to 90,000 commercial vehicles every year. The Chief Minister reviewed the project layout, drainage systems, and future expansion plans during the visit. She directed officials to ensure strict quality stan-

dards and timely completion of the project. Officials said the new ATS facility is expected to modernise vehicle fitness testing and improve transparency in inspections once operational. Reviewing the overall condition of the DTO complex, the Chief Minister said minor repairs would not be enough and asked officials to prepare a comprehensive redevelopment plan for the campus.

She said the existing premises should be transformed into a model transport service centre equipped with modern infrastructure and better public facilities.

The proposed redevelopment plan, according to officials, will include upgraded administrative offices, parking facilities, green areas, training infrastructure, and improved citizen amenities. The Chief Minister also visited the Vehicle Inspection Unit and observed that several structures and systems at the facility had become outdated.

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33%	TURNOVER ₹ 31,554 Cr.	61%	TURNOVER ₹ 11,173 Cr.
11%	PAT ₹ 7,421 Cr.	35%	PAT ₹ 2,020 Cr.
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13%	SALES 50.24 MnT	21%	SALES 15.30 MnT

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IN FOCUS



UP CM Yogi interacting with a child during the foundation stone laying ceremony of various projects in Hariharpur, Kushinagar district

PTI

Maharashtra Govt acquires iconic Air India building in Mumbai



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra government on Tuesday formally acquired the iconic Air India building, a defining feature of the south Mumbai skyline known for its prime sea-facing location, for ₹1,601 crore.

The transfer of agreements between Air India Assets Holding Company and the state Public Works Department (PWD) was completed in the presence of Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis in the Cabinet Hall at 'Mantralaya' or state secretariat following a cabinet meeting, an official release said. Deputy Chief Minister Sunetra Pawar, Tourism Minister Shambhuraj Desai, Public Works Minister Shivendrasinhraje Bhosale, Chief Secretary Rajesh Agrawal, Additional Chief Secretary (PWD) Milind Mhaikar, Mumbai City Collector Anchal Goyal and officials of Air India including its commercial officer attended the event.

Govt transfers top CBSE officials

The committee will submit its report to the Department of Personnel and Training within one month. The move comes after weeks of scrutiny over CBSE's evaluation and post-result processes, which sparked concerns among students, parents and teachers across the country in the wake of irregularities in the digital evaluation system for the class 12 examination process.

Concerns were raised by students and parents over the implementation of the OSM system in the CBSE board examination process. The board has faced criticism over technical glitches, payment failures and delays in the verification and re-evaluation process, prompting demands for greater transparency and accountability.

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CBSE re-evaluation portal faces new cyber...

The standard fees are ₹100 per answer book for photocopying and ₹25 per question for re-evaluation. CBSE provided step-by-step guides and set up an email support channel for students with login or session issues.

The re-evaluation portal was introduced for the 2026 Class 12 exams, after nearly one in every four Class 12 students sought scanned copies of their answer sheets. Reported problems included missing pages, unchecked answers, and errors in the On Screen Marking (OSM) system.

Earlier, a 19-year-old Class 12 student named Nisarga Adhikary from West Bengal broke into the OSM test portal in under 30 minutes and exposed vulnerabilities. He said he could create, read, update and delete data, had shell access on the servers, and found master passwords that could bypass OTP verification. Adhikary reported these security problems to CERT-In, CBSE, and the Ministry of Education. CBSE maintained until very recently that exams are held offline and are unaffected. Further, it claimed that only evaluators could access the OSM portal and said the vulnerabilities had been fixed. Adhikary, however, kept sharing documentation of the alleged flaws.

In late May, an incident disrupted the re-eval-

uation portal's payment system, affecting about 50 student transactions. Payment issues led to refunds and a temporary shutdown. Authorities confirmed there were unauthorised logins and delayed the full re-evaluation rollout.

From Ranchi to Parliament, a teen...

He also presented a seven-page copy of his findings before the Parliamentary Committee chaired by Congress MP Digvijaya Singh, who heard him patiently and demanded answers from CBSE officials.

Sources said Sarthak systematically presented his arguments to the members, highlighting various discrepancies from the misrepresented financial criteria, the failure to disclose its blacklisted earlier status to the fact that the company's previous avatar, Globarena, had worked for the Telangana Education Board. The CBSE is scheduled to give its responses to the questions raised by Sarthak in the committee's next meeting.

Sources said the committee members demanded that the CBSE identify those responsible for the events that transpired and the disciplinary action taken against them, emphasising that accountability must be ensured following such incidents.

The CBSE too handed over a report to the panel members, presenting their side on the problems faced by students, and assured the MPs that the glitches that appeared on its portal have since been rectified and students now have time till June 6 to apply for re-evaluation of their answer-sheets.

Amid a row over the CBSE's on-screen marking system, the committee had summoned top officials of the board and the Ministry of School Education to discuss the issue of using the online marking system (OSM) in the Class-12 exams and the problems faced by students consequently. The panel also discussed applying the three-language formula in Classes 9 and 10 with the education ministry officials.

Iran stops talks over attacks on Lebanon

Israeli drone strikes on southern Lebanon on Tuesday killed eight people, including a father and his son and daughter, a day after US

India sends Ebola relief aid to Africa CDC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Amid the outbreak of Ebola in parts of the African continent, India has dispatched the second tranche of medical assistance to the Africa Centres for Disease Control and Prevention (Africa CDC) comprising protective gear, diagnostic and monitoring equipment, infection prevention supplies and medicines and supplements.

On May 17, the World Health Organisation (WHO) declared the Ebola outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo and Uganda a Public Health Emergency of International Concern.

As an urgent response, the first tranche of about 2.5 tonnes of urgent medical supplies was dispatched on May 24 to Kampala, Uganda, comprising protective gear, medical monitoring equipment, essential medicines and supplements, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Tuesday.

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar in a post on X shared an



update on the second tranche of medical assistance sent to Africa CDC and some photos of the consignment.

"India has dispatched the second tranche of medical assistance to @AfricaCDC, comprising protective gear, diagnostic & monitoring equipment, medicines, and supplements. Confident that this 43

tons consignment will further strengthen public health preparedness and bolster Ebola response capacities across @.AfricanUnion," he said on Tuesday.

The MEA in its statement said after receiving a more detailed list of requirements from Africa CDC, it mobilised a larger second tranche, comprising protective gear, diagnos-

tic and monitoring devices, sample transport kits, infection prevention supplies, medicines and supplements. The second tranche will be reaching Kampala on Tuesday and will be handed over to Africa CDC, it said.

India has extended urgent medical assistance to the Africa CDC to support their Ebola response efforts after receiving a request from the African Union Commission, it said. "India's support is tailored to meet the needs of Africa CDC to contain the Ebola outbreak in some parts of Africa, and to strengthen public health preparedness and regional response capacities," the MEA added.

India's support reflects its "enduring commitment" to partnership with African countries, including in supporting them to respond to public health situations in the continent. "Our Missions in Addis Ababa and Kampala remain closely engaged with the African Union Commission and the Africa CDC for supporting their Ebola response efforts," it said.

Police book AAP leader for revealing minor sexual assault victim's identity

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police has booked Aam Aadmi Party's Delhi unit chief Saurabh Bhardwaj for allegedly disclosing the identity of a three-year-old girl who was allegedly sexually assaulted at a private school in west Delhi's Janakpuri area.

According to police, the FIR has been registered under Section 72 of the BharatiyaNyayaSanhita (BNS), 2023, Section 74 of the Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015, and Section 23(4) of the Protection of Children



from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012, which prohibit the disclosure of

the identity of child victims. A three-year-old girl was allegedly sexually assaulted

by a 57-year-old staff member inside a private school. The incident came to light on May 1 after the child's mother approached the police.

The accused was later granted bail by a Dwarka court. In a recent development, Delhi Police also arrested a female teacher from the school after gathering evidence during the investigation. A court granted one-day custodial remand of the teacher for further questioning.

Addressing a press conference, Aam Aadmi Party chief Saurabh Bhardwaj on Tuesday alleged that the

BJP had lodged an FIR against him for naming a private school while raising the alleged sexual assault of a three-year-old girl in Janakpuri.

Bhardwaj claimed that he had highlighted concerns raised by the child's family, who had alleged that attempts were being made to suppress the case due to the school's alleged political connections.

He said the issue was brought into the public domain so that parents whose children study or may study at the school in the future could be aware of the allegations surrounding

the institution's handling of the case. He also referred to reports that several CCTV cameras on the school premises were not functioning, claiming this had hampered the availability of evidence in the case.

Rejecting the charge, Bhardwaj said he did not know the victim's name or the identities of her parents and had only referred to the name of the school while discussing the case.

"It is important for society, Delhi residents and parents to know how the management of the school allegedly behaved with the victim and her family," he said.

India successfully test-fires RudraM-II missiles

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

The DRDO and the Indian Air Force have conducted the successful flight-tests of RudraM-II air-to-surface missiles from an airborne platform, the defence ministry said on Tuesday.

The missiles, after release, were guided to a predefined target with pin-point accuracy, it said, adding all the test objectives were "fully" met.

The ministry said the tests were conducted "under extreme release conditions" with critical trajectory establishing the capability of all subsystems.

The range of the missile is



around 350 kms. "The missiles after release were guided to a predefined target with pin-point accuracy. All the test objectives were fully met as confirmed by the flight data captured by

various range instruments deployed by Integrated Test Range (ITR), Chandipur," the ministry said in a statement.

RudraM-II has been indigenously developed by Research Centre Imarat,

Hyderabad as the nodal DRDO laboratory in collaboration with other sister labs such as Defence Research and Development Laboratory, High Energy Materials Research Laboratory, Armament Research and Development Establishment and ITR.

Along with the Development cum Production Partners (DcPPs), agencies like Hindustan Aeronautics Limited, Regional Centre for Military Airworthiness, Missile System Quality Assurance Agency and several industries have contributed significantly towards achieving this goal, the ministry said.

Gujarat GST squad seizes gold, silver, precious stones worth ₹4.25 crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Ahmedabad

In one of its largest enforcement actions to date, Gujarat's State GST Department has seized precious metals and gemstones valued at approximately ₹4.25 crore during an inspection of a private passenger bus.

Officials from the department's Mobile Squad intercepted the vehicle after receiving intelligence inputs regarding the transportation of high-value goods. During the inspection, authorities recovered around 120 kilograms of



silver, nearly 700 grams of gold and approximately three kilograms of precious stones. Preliminary findings indicated that the consignment was being transported without the mandatory supporting documents

required under tax regulations. Officials sought invoices and other records related to the shipment but reportedly did not receive satisfactory documentation.

The entire consignment has been confiscated pending further investigation. Authorities are examining the origin and intended destination of the goods while also exploring possible tax evasion and compliance violations. Sources indicated that the valuables were allegedly being transported from another state before being intercepted in Ahmedabad.

FROM PAGE - 1

President Donald Trump said Israel and Hezbollah agreed to dial back fighting. Israel threatened on Monday to strike Beirut's southern suburbs, causing panic in the Lebanese capital as thousands fled to safer areas and Hezbollah fired rockets at northern Israel.

Israeli forces recently made their deepest incursion into Lebanon in 26 years, but Beirut has been mostly spared over the past six weeks, apart from two targeted attacks on the city's southern suburbs in May.

Trump later announced after a call with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and communicating with the Lebanese militant group through mediators that "there will be no Troops going to Beirut".

Lebanon's State-run *National News Agency (NNA)* reported Tuesday that an Israeli drone strike hit a car on the road linking the southern town of Marjayoun with the city of Nabatiyeh, killing James Karam, a dentist from the nearby Christian town of Qlayaa, along with his daughter and son. The Lebanese army said two soldiers were lightly wounded when a separate drone targeted them on a road outside the city.

A drone strike on the village of Jibchit killed two Syrians who worked at a plant nursery, the agency reported, while another on the nearby village of Toul killed two people. A third strike hit a car near the village of Harouf, killing one person.

NNA also reported that an Israeli airstrike on Monday killed six in the southern village of Marwanieh.

Hezbollah said Tuesday its fighters fired anti-tank missiles on Israeli troops who were pushing into the southern village of Hadatha, about 7 km from the Israeli border. Sirens sounded in several areas in northern Israel, the military said in a statement, adding that "a suspicious aerial target" was identified in the area in which Israeli soldiers are operating in southern Lebanon, and that no injuries were reported.

Despite a Washington-brokered ceasefire reached in April, the two sides have continued to exchange strikes after Israel targeted areas in Lebanon, saying it was for self-defence.

The latest exchanges came as a second round of talks between Israel and Lebanon is scheduled for Tuesday and Wednesday in Washington, where Lebanese negotiators are set to seek a full ceasefire that will prevent future attacks.

The Israel-Lebanon talks that began in April in Washington were the first in more than three decades between the countries, which have no

formal diplomatic relations. The fighting presents a major obstacle to the emerging deal to extend the ceasefire in the Iran war that erupted after the United States and Israel struck the Islamic Kingdom on Feb 28. Tehran wants any agreement to include a complete ceasefire in Lebanon.

Compassionate appointment cannot...

"Such a presumption is incompatible with the constitutional guarantee of equality and perpetuates historical notions of gender inequality which the Constitution seeks to eradicate," the bench said.

It rejected the submission of the State that a married daughter may not satisfy the requirement of local residence is equally untenable.

The top court said a blanket exclusion of all married daughters cannot be justified on the speculative assumption that every married daughter necessarily resides elsewhere.

Constitutional adjudication cannot be founded on presumptions that are overboard and disconnected from lived realities, it said.

"The purpose of the dependent quota is neither to create a right of succession or inheritance in the dealership nor a reward for lineage. The object is limited and specific: to provide immediate financial relief to the dependent family of a deceased dealer and to ensure continuity in the public distribution system.

"Once dependency is accepted as the governing criterion, exclusion of a married daughter solely on account of her marital status becomes wholly irrational and self-defeating. We are, therefore, of the considered view that the exclusion of married daughters from the definition of 'family' fails the test of reasonable classification and is manifestly arbitrary," the bench said.

The top court said in the present case, the material on record establishes that the woman continued to reside in the same village even after her marriage and actively assisted her mother in the operation of the fair price shop.

"The appellant, upon her mother's demise, assumed responsibility for maintaining her sisters, including a visually impaired sister.

"The authorities have not disputed these factual assertions. The sole ground on which her application was rejected was that she is a married daughter. Once that ground is held to

be constitutionally invalid, no impediment survives to the grant of relief in her favour," it said.

India rejects EU-Pakistan reference to J&K

"The Pakistani side briefed on the issue of Jammu and Kashmir. The EU side briefed on Russia's war against Ukraine," the press communiqué read. Last month, India similarly dismissed references to Jammu and Kashmir in a joint statement issued by Pakistan and China. Replying to media questions about references to Jammu and Kashmir in the China-Pakistan joint statement, Jaishankar said India's position has remained unchanged and is well known to both countries.

He also said India opposes attempts by any country to support or legitimise Pakistan's control over territories linked to the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC), which India considers a violation of its sovereignty and territorial integrity.

ED raids 20 sites, tightens net around Dola

A close associate of Dawood Ibrahim, 59-year-old Dola, is a resident of Dongri in Mumbai. He was extradited from Türkiye in April 2026. His arrest was triggered by an Interpol Red Notice issued by India in March 2024. Dola had lived in Istanbul's Beylikdüzü district under the alias 'Hamza' (and reportedly 'Abdul'). Turkish police located him after he reportedly placed a courier delivery order. Three passports were recovered: two Indian and one Bulgarian. He allegedly used the Bulgarian document and considered buying property in Türkiye to obtain citizenship.

The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) arrested him following his extradition and is being questioned about his network. His record includes involvement in major drug seizures, such as heroin, charas, and mephedrone. In one case, authorities found 126 kg of cash worth 725.22 lakh. He is also linked to mandrax and methamphetamine cases in Maharashtra and Gujarat.

His arrest is the first major success of Operation Global Hunt, which targets D-Company's drug operations and aims to stop crime funding that may support terrorism. In 2025, Dola's son Tahil (also known as Taher) and his associates were deported from the UAE and arrested by Mumbai Police.

Jaishankar holds talks with South African Dy President

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

South Africa's Deputy President Shipokosa Paulus Mashatile and External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Tuesday held wide-ranging talks focusing on boosting bilateral ties in trade, investments, infrastructure and the digital domain.

In the delegation-level meeting, the two sides also agreed that India and South Africa must work closely in international forums.

The South African deputy president also met Vice President C P Radhakrishnan and discussed various aspects of historical, cultural and people-to-people relations between the two nations.

Mashatile, accompanied by his wife Humile Mashatile and a high-powered delegation comprising five ministers



External Affairs Minister Dr S Jaishankar, left, poses for photographs with Deputy President of the Republic of South Africa Paul Mashatile during a meeting, New Delhi

and deputy ministers, is on a six-day visit to India from May 29 with an aim to promote South Africa as a competitive investment destination and to enhance the bilateral trade relations. Following his talks with

Jaishankar, Mashatile said both sides agreed that South Africa and India should broaden their ties, especially in the economic sectors. "Pleased to meet with Deputy President Shipokosa Paulus Mashatile@PMashatile

of the Republic of South Africa along with his delegation in New Delhi today," the external affairs minister said on social media.

"Appreciate his strong commitment to deepening our longstanding partnership. Discussed opportunities in trade, investments, MSMEs, digital and infrastructure domains. Also agreed that India and South Africa must work closely in international forums," he said.

During the meeting with the Vice President, the two leaders held comprehensive discussions aimed at strengthening the longstanding partnership between India and South Africa, the Vice President secretariat said. Key areas of focus included trade, investment, defence cooperation, skills development, and enhancing people-to-people exchanges.

Centre inks MoU with 4 States, UT to boost rural water supply under Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Central Government on Tuesday signed agreements with the states of Arunachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Tamil Nadu, Nagaland and the Union Territory of Puducherry to strengthen rural drinking water supply systems under Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0.

The Memorandum of Understanding were signed during separate virtual meetings attended by Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil, Minister of State V Somanna and chief ministers of the respective states and Union Territory.

The agreements sought to institutionalise a model of



rural water governance led by gram panchayats and were service-based and community-centred. The model aims to focus on the sustainability, quality, operation and maintenance, and community ownership of rural water supply infrastructure, according to a statement.

Addressing the virtual meetings, Patil said gram panchayats, district and state water and sanitation missions, and local communities must work together to ensure reliable drinking water services.

Highlighting the challenges posed by mountainous

terrain and heavy rainfall in Arunachal Pradesh, Patil said a revised Operation and Maintenance Policy will be notified for the state soon.

He called for regular meetings of district water and sanitation missions, faster accreditation of laboratories and observance of "Jal Arpan Diwas" for formal handover of water assets to gram panchayats.

In the case of Jharkhand, Patil laid emphasis on proper operation and maintenance, source sustainability and water conservation. He urged the state government to expedite the ongoing works so that all remaining rural households receive safe drinking water.

Foreigners on visas under 180 days must register before expiry: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Foreigners visiting India on a visa for 180 days or less must now register themselves at any time before their visa expires if they want to stay longer, according to changes in the Immigration and Foreigners Rules, 2025, announced by the Union Home Ministry.

The new rule, announced on Monday, replaces the previous requirement for foreigners to register within 14 days after staying 180 days in India.

The notification published in the gazette stated: In rule 12 of the Immigration and Foreigners Rules, 2025, in sub-rule (1), and in the third proviso, the previous words "within fourteen days after the expiry of one hundred



and eighty days of his arrival in India" are substituted with "any time before the expiry of the said period of one hundred and eighty days."

Foreigners with a visa for more than 180 days must register before their 180-day period ends if they want to extend their stay. The new rule also states that registration will only be allowed in urgent situations.

The updated rules also offer some relief for children

born to foreign parents. Previously, parents had to inform the registration officer online within 30 days if their child was born under these circumstances.

This was needed to access visa services, such as getting a new visa or exit permission, through the online portal or app.

This rule does not apply if one parent is an Indian citizen and wants their child to keep Indian citizenship. However, if the child gets foreign citizenship while in India, a parent must inform the registration officer within 30 days of this change. The notification also updates the reporting and administrative rules for hospitals, nursing homes, and other medical institutions that offer medical care, lodging, or sleeping facilities.

ED launches FEMA probe against Vedanta Group over brand fee refund

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has initiated a foreign exchange violation investigation against billionaire Anil Agarwal's Vedanta Group and carried out searches at multiple official premises of the company, officials said on Tuesday.

The raids were conducted on Monday at four locations of Vedanta Ltd, including offices in Delhi, Mumbai and Udaipur in Rajasthan, the officials said.

The probe is being conducted under the civil provisions of the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA). At the centre of the investigation is an instance in 2023 when Vedanta Resources, the London-based parent of Indian-listed Vedanta Ltd, refunded a part of the brand fee to its Indian arm, officials said. The federal agency is also examining other financial structures within the group, they added.



A Vedanta spokesperson confirmed the ED action and said the company was "extending full cooperation to the authorities and is providing all information sought."

"The company remains committed to compliance with all applicable laws and regulations. As the matter is currently under the regulatory process, we are unable to comment further at this stage," the spokesperson added. Vedanta Ltd is a leading global producer of metals and critical minerals with operations across India,

Africa, the Middle East and East Asia.

The company recently received board approval for a major demerger plan under which its businesses will be reorganised and listed as four separate entities: Vedanta Aluminium Metal Limited (VAML), Talwandi Sabo Power Ltd (TSPL), Malco Energy Ltd (MEL) and Vedanta Iron and Steel Limited (VISL).

The development comes at a time when the conglomerate is restructuring its operations into independent verticals.

WAVES OTT CROSSES ONE CRORE USERS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prasar Bharati's digital streaming platform WAVES OTT has crossed one crore registered users, marking a significant milestone in the growth of India's public service digital media ecosystem, the public broadcaster said in a statement on Tuesday.

Prasar Bharati said the platform has emerged as one of the country's largest public streaming destinations, offering free access to more than 24,000 content titles, over 15,000 hours of programming and 140 live television channels.

According to the statement, WAVES OTT, which was launched in November 2024, now reaches audiences in more than 130 countries through mobile, web and connected TV devices, with content available in multiple Indian languages. The platform hosts content spanning entertainment, news, education, culture, spirituality and public service genres.

It also offers more than 200 radio services, live event streaming, educational programming through PM eVidya channels, digital editions of publications such as Yojana, Kurukshetra and Rozgar Samachar, devotional streams from prominent temples and archival content from Prasar Bharati.

"The achievement demonstrates the growing relevance of digital public service media in the digital age and validates the vision of creating a single destination for television, radio, on-demand content, education, culture and heritage," it said.

WAVES OTT, which has recorded more than 1.4 crore downloads and is now targeting two crore registered users by March 2027.

Shivakumar to be sworn in as CM on June 3



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

State Congress President D K Shivakumar will be sworn in as the CM of Karnataka on Wednesday, along with some ministers, in a ceremony at Lok Bhavan here, sources said.

The 64-year-old Vokkaliga strongman, who was elected leader of the Congress Legislature Party in Karnataka on May 30, will be administered the oath of office and secrecy by Governor Thaaawarchand Gehlot at 4.05 pm at Lok Bhavan's Glass House.

Though it is not officially known how many ministers will take oath on Wednesday in the first phase, sources suggest that 12 to 14 may be sworn in.

By assuming the state's highest political office, the eight-time MLA "DK Shi," as he is popularly called, Shivakumar will fulfil his long-cherished dream after a prolonged power tussle with outgoing CM Siddaramaiah.

Siddaramaiah resigned as CM last week, as directed by the Congress high command, paving the way for Shivakumar, who is considered the party's trouble-shooter in South India, to take the coveted position.

Final preparations were underway at Lok Bhavan on Tuesday.

The ceremony is reportedly low-key due to concerns over peak-hour traffic disruption in Bengaluru caused by the anticipated influx of Congress workers and supporters from across the state.

The swearing-in was earlier planned to be held on the grand steps of Vidhana Soudha in front of a large gathering.

According to sources, AICC President Mallikarjun Kharge, Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, and party General Secretaries K C Venugopal and Randeep Singh Surjewala are expected to attend the event.

CMs from Congress and INDIA bloc-ruled states, along with several state and central leaders, dignitaries, and invitees, are also expected to be present.

Religious leaders of all major communities, including heads of various maths, have been invited, sources said. Meanwhile, hectic parleys continued in New Delhi on Tuesday involving the Congress high command, Shivakumar, and Siddaramaiah regarding the composition of the Council of Ministers.

Kharge and Rahul Gandhi also attended the meetings. The sanctioned strength of Karnataka's ministry is 34, including the CM.

States Focus



MURUGAN PLEDGES SUPPORT FOR MIZORAM'S MEDIA, FILM INDUSTRY

Union Minister L Murugan on Tuesday pledged the Centre's support to promote Mizoram's media and film industry sector, official sources said.

Murugan, the Union Minister of State for Information and Broadcasting and Parliamentary Affairs, arrived in Aizawl on a two-day official visit to the northeastern state. Immediately upon his arrival at Lengpui airport, the Union Minister held discussions with the state Information and Public Relations Minister B Lalchhanzova on strengthening the media, film and digital infrastructure sectors before proceeding to Kolasib district for official engagements, the sources said. During the meeting, Lalchhanzova pitched a series of ambitious proposals aimed at revolutionising the state's media, digital infrastructure, and creative economy, it said. (PTI)



TELANGANA CONGRESS LEADERS BEHAVING LIKE SEPARATISTS: KALYAN

Strongly opposing objection by some Telangana Congress leaders to a proposed Jana Sena party meet here, Andhra Pradesh Deputy Chief Minister Pawan Kalyan on Tuesday alleged that few leaders of the grand old party were behaving like separatists.

The Jana Sena founder leader demanded that top Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra "respond" to such narrow regional politics of some Telangana Congress leaders. While Jana Sena respects regional sentiments, it would resist if regionalism hurts nationalism, he said. (PTI)

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States Focus



EDUCATION WILL BUILD A STRONG, SELF-RELIANT INDIA: MURMU

President Droupadi Murmu on Tuesday said that when youth advance on the strength of education and technology, they will build a strong, prosperous, and self-reliant India. Addressing a group of beneficiaries of the Ministry of Tribal Affairs' flagship scholarship schemes, she said the Government of India is making continuous efforts, through various schemes, to empower and uplift the youth belonging to tribal communities. Murmu said that education is a vital instrument of empowerment, and it possesses the power to render an individual self-reliant. She stated that education has played a major role in her life journey as well. The president said that the education and experiences of young people should serve as an inspiration for those children who, despite having limited resources, dare to dream big. (PTI)



MANOHAR CHAIRS PARLIAMENTARY CONSULTATIVE COMMITTEE MEETING

Union Minister Manohar Lal on Tuesday chaired a parliamentary consultative committee meeting under the Power Ministry, where discussions centred on creating a robust, future-ready power grid to support India's clean energy initiatives. "Our discussions focused on building a robust and future-ready power grid to support India's clean energy ambitions," Lal said. The members also exchanged views on enhancing grid resilience through transmission expansion, energy storage, renewable integration, advanced forecasting, and deployment of technologies that strengthen system stability, the minister said after the meeting. The meeting focused on grid stability amid rising electricity demand, large-scale renewable energy integration, and the increasing share of inverter-based resources. (PTI)

CM Suwendu to launch Annapurna Yojana

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari will formally inaugurate the state's Annapurna Yojana on Wednesday, in which women beneficiaries will get ₹3,000 a month, according to an official order.

Annapurna Yojana, one of the key promises made in the BJP's election manifesto, will replace the previous TMC Government's 'Lakshmi Bhandar', under which beneficiaries used to get a maximum of ₹1,500 per month. "The chief minister will inaugurate Annapurna Yojana on June 3," an order issued by the state secretary-at said on Wednesday.

The Women and Child Development and Social Welfare Department directed district administrations to make necessary arrangements to ensure that the programme is conducted smoothly across the state.

The order said that beneficiaries of the scheme would participate virtually from block and municipal-level venues. "The CM's programme will be connected through a virtual conference at all Blocks/Municipalities. District Magistrates are requested to ensure that the programme is done properly," it said. MLAs would be invited to attend the programmes in their respective areas. As part of the launch event, sanction letters will be distributed to selected beneficiaries immediately after the inauguration.

According to the order, 100 beneficiaries of the Annapurna Yojana from each block, municipality and the Kolkata Municipal Corporation will receive sanction letters on the day.



Mamata protests attacks on TMC workers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

Trinamool Congress supremo Mamata Banerjee on Tuesday held a dharna in central Kolkata to protest against alleged post-poll attacks on party workers and leaders following the BJP's victory in recent assembly elections.

Banerjee asserted that she would not abandon TMC workers after the party's defeat in the recent assembly polls. Addressing TMC supporters at her day-long dharna at Esplanade's Y-channel, Banerjee said anti-BJP parties would soon formulate a country-wide opposition programme.

"Very soon, all anti-BJP parties will meet in Delhi. Wait for a few days and we will soon announce our country-wide course of



TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee holds a sit-in protest against the alleged attacks on party leaders and workers in Kolkata

action," the TMC chief said, referring to the scheduled INDIA bloc meeting next week. Banerjee reached the dharna site after the TMC's appeal to

use microphones," Banerjee said, while addressing the crowd using a megaphone. The protest was marked by chaos, with TMC workers shouting slogans amid the former chief minister's speech.

Banerjee was seen accompanied by the party's old guards Firhad Hakim, Madan Mitra, Derek O'Brien, Kalyan Banerjee and Dola Sen, amid the conspicuous absence of most of the fresh faces who won the assembly seats on TMC tickets.

The party supremo, however, asserted that the dharna, to protest Saturday's attack on her nephew and TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee, alleged post-poll violence and hawker eviction, will continue till the evening as scheduled.

the representatives of the Ladakh Apex Body (LAB) and the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA).

In her communication to Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, Mufti wrote, "I had sought an appointment with you, but due to your preoccupation, it has not been possible." Therefore, I am taking the liberty of writing to you since time is running out and we cannot afford to delay things any further. Recent breakthroughs achieved by the Leh Apex Body & Kargil Democratic Alliance with the Centre offer an important lesson – only dialogue can deliver meaningful outcomes."

Cornered, Omar Abdullah responded to PDP president Mehbooba Mufti over her recent letter seeking a united political outreach to the centre, saying her communi-

TMC HEADING TOWARDS A SPLIT: TAPAS ROY

Kolkata: West Bengal minister Tapas Roy on Tuesday claimed that the opposition TMC was heading towards a split similar to the ones witnessed in Maharashtra. Speaking to reporters outside the assembly, Roy claimed the TMC had accommodated people with little political background and that internal contradictions were now surfacing. BJP MLA of Maniktala claimed it would eventually disappear from the state's political landscape. "There is growing dissatisfaction among many leaders and legislators. The developments indicate that the party is heading towards a split, a situation similar to what happened in Maharashtra," claimed the veteran leader, who switched

over to the BJP from the TMC in 2024. Earlier, senior TMC MLA Sobhandeb asserted that the majority of the party legislators would remain with supremo Mamata, and the old guards would continue to retain control of the organisation. He alleged that attempts were being made by the ruling dispensation to engineer defections and destabilise the opposition but maintained that the TMC was united. Expelled TMC MLA Ritabrata, who is believed to be the leader of the rebel camp, claimed that the party has been "hijacked by I-PAC and no longer belongs to Mamata". Banerjee made the comment outside the assembly, with his visit to the House when it is not in session fuelling further speculations. (PTI)

7 dead, 40 injured in Surat bus collision

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Surat

At least seven persons were killed, and around 40 were injured after two buses operated by the Maharashtra State Road Transport Corporation (MSRTC) collided near Bardoli town in Gujarat's Surat district on Tuesday, and one of them caught fire, police said.

All the deceased were travelling in the bus that caught fire. The incident occurred on National Highway No 53 near Uva village, officials said, adding that the road connects Maharashtra with Gujarat. Surat district Superintendent of Police Rajesh Ghadhiya said one of the buses was travelling from Surat to Dhule, while the other was headed towards Surat from Chalisgaon in Maharashtra. "On the highway from Bardoli to



Vyara, the bus headed to Maharashtra hit a tractor. After losing balance, it jumped the divider and collided with the bus coming from the Maharashtra side, causing it to overturn and land in a low-lying area beside the road. The bus caught fire," said Ghadhiya.

He said teams of police, fire brigade and officials from Surat and the neighbouring Tapi district rushed to the spot and launched rescue operations immediately.

Mehbooba bowls fresh googly to trap J&K CM Omar Abdullah ahead of NC meet

MOHIT KANDHARI
Jammu

Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) President and former Chief Minister Chief Mehbooba Mufti Tuesday bowled a fresh googly to trap J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah ahead of the much-hyped meeting of the ruling party legislators in Srinagar on June 3.

In a surprise development, Mehbooba Mufti reached out to a wide spectrum of political and civil society leaders, urging them to set aside differences and jointly engage with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah for initiating a sustained dialogue process on Jammu and Kashmir. She took a cue from the recent round of dialogue between the Ministry of Home Affairs and



cation created an impression that she had been awaiting an appointment for a long time, which was "clearly not the case". In a post on X, CM Omar Abdullah said that Mehbooba Mufti had spoken to him on Saturday and requested a meeting. He stated that he informed her that he would be in Pahalgam on Sunday and would get in touch on Monday or Tuesday to fix a meeting.

"Mehbooba Mufti Sahiba, we spoke on Saturday when

you asked to meet. I told you I was in Pahalgam on Sunday & would get in touch on Monday or Tuesday to fix to meet," Omar Abdullah wrote.

The Chief Minister said Mufti's letter gives the impression that she had been waiting for an appointment "for weeks on end", which, he maintained, was not the reality. Omar Abdullah further noted that since Mufti's letter had already been placed in the public domain, he would also issue his response through the same route after consulting senior colleagues in the National Conference.

"Be that as it may, your letter to me is now in the public domain, and I will be sending you a reply, similarly routed, once I've consulted my senior party colleagues," the Chief Minister added.

Will not contest in Trichy by-election: VCK chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Chennai

VCK chief Thol Thirumavalavan on Tuesday announced that he will not contest from the Tiruchirappalli East Assembly constituency vacated by Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, clarifying that he has no desire to become a minister in the TVK cabinet.

The Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi founder stated that he would not contest any by-elections and would not be influenced by anyone. His remarks come following speculations that the TVK's ally leader will make it to the Assembly from the Tiruchirappalli East



VCK chief Thol Thirumavalavan

seat that was won by Vijay in the April 23 Assembly polls. After his victory from two constituencies, Vijay vacated Tiruchirappalli East and retained the Perambur constituency in Chennai. "I am

saying this 100 per cent: I will not contest in any by-elections, nor will I be influenced by anyone," Thirumavalavan said in a video message and revealed that he was offered a chance to contest from the constituency, which was vacated by Vijay, as per ECI norms, with the promise of a ministerial berth upon his victory. "I have denied it from my side, and I thank Chief Minister Vijay for the offer," he said.

Thirumavalavan's VCK, along with the Left parties and IUML, had extended support to the Vijay-led TVK in forming the Government, while the Congress had joined Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam in

a post-poll pact.

Explaining that his support to the TVK was extended only after consulting DMK president M. K. Stalin, he stressed that the support was mainly to prevent the implementation of the President's rule in Tamil Nadu. "I have been the harshest critic of Vijay before the election and even accused him of attempting to divide the minority votes and hindering the progress of the Secular Progress Alliance," the VCK chief said and rejected the TVK offer, stating that he was not power-hungry and has always been committed to safeguarding the DMK-led alliance.

Andhra CM seeks Centre's intervention over laterite mine classification changes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Tuesday urged the Centre to take immediate steps to address issues arising from changes in the classification of laterite mines.

In a letter to Union Mines Minister G Kishan Reddy, the chief minister sought inter-

vention to protect pending mining lease applications affected by the recent decision to classify laterite with 20 per cent or more aluminium content as bauxite instead of a minor mineral.

"I request the Union Government to provide a saving clause for laterite and allow the pending applications to be processed under the earlier rules with a relaxation period of two years,"

Naidu said in an official release.

The chief minister said the Centre's decision has brought the mining lease process in Andhra Pradesh to a standstill, forcing the state government to temporarily keep on hold 402 applications that were earlier processed under the minor mineral category.

He said the pending applications comprise 19 Letter of



Intent applications, 113 government land applications, 255 forest land applications and 15 patta land applications. Naidu noted that hundreds of applicants had already spent crores of rupees towards application fees, land purchases and forest clearances under the earlier regulatory framework.

He recalled that when minerals such as mica, quartz,

feldspar and barytes were reclassified from minor minerals to major minerals in the past, the Centre had provided a saving clause and sought similar relief for laterite.

The CM said such a relaxation would prevent financial losses to hundreds of applicants and help avoid potential legal disputes arising from the change in classification.

Congress' Wajed Ali named Leader of Opposition in Assam Assembly

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Guwahati

Senior Congress leader Wajed Ali Choudhury has been named Leader of the Opposition in the Assam assembly, an official communique said on Tuesday.

In a Facebook post, the Assam Legislative Assembly said Choudhury has been entrusted with the role of LoP by Speaker Ranjeet Kumar Dass. On May 26, the Congress had named Choudhury as the leader of its Legislative Party in Assam, and Joy Prakash Das was appointed deputy leader of the Congress Legislature Party.

The NDA, comprising the



Wajed Ali Choudhury

BJP, Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) and Bodoland People's Front (BPF), secured a sweeping mandate in the assembly polls, winning a record 102 seats in the 126-member House. The BJP alone bagged 82, while AGP and BPF won 10 seats each. The Congress

and Raijor Dal, who were part of a six-party opposition alliance, won 19 and two seats, respectively.

The AIUDF and Trinamool Congress fought separately as single entities and have two and one MLAs, respectively.

Haryana revises PG policy for in-service Govt doctors

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Chandigarh

Haryana has revised its policy for in-service doctors pursuing postgraduate medical education to address faculty shortages in government medical colleges and ensure the availability of specialist doctors in hospitals, officials said on Tuesday.

Additional Chief Secretary of Health and Family Welfare in the Medical Education and Research Department, Sumita Misra, said under the amended policy issued by the Department of Medical Education and Research (DMER), in-service doctors who obtain postgraduate degrees in clinical specialties while in government

service will no longer be required to execute a medical education bond and will continue serving in their parent departments.

The decision is expected to strengthen specialist healthcare delivery across Haryana, an official statement said.

The amendment modifies provisions of the government's 2022 policy relating to incentivising in-service doctors for pursuing postgraduate studies under the reservation quota available in Haryana's medical colleges, it said.

According to the revised policy, in-service doctors who complete postgraduate courses in pre-clinical and para-clinical disciplines by availing reservation benefits in state medical colleges



will be required to serve for three years in medical education institutions functioning under the DMER.

After completing the mandatory tenure, these doctors will be given the option of permanent absorption in the Medical Education and Research Department, creating a dedicated pathway for developing teaching faculty in government medical colleges.

The move comes at a time

when Haryana has rapidly expanded its medical education infrastructure with the establishment of new government medical colleges, increasing the demand for qualified teachers in subjects such as Anatomy, Physiology, Biochemistry, Pharmacology, Pathology and Microbiology.

The notable aspect of the policy is the exemption granted to doctors pursuing postgraduate studies in clinical branches. Such doctors, along with Haryana Civil Dental Service (HCDS) officers, will not be required to furnish a Medical Education Bond and will continue their services in their respective parent departments after completing their higher studies.

Won't scrap Ladki Bahin scheme: Fadnavis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Tuesday assured that the Government will not discontinue its flagship 'Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin' welfare scheme, clarifying that 1.70 crore eligible women will keep receiving benefits despite the recent removal of lakhs of beneficiaries.

The chief minister's remarks have come after the April 30 deadline for e-KYC (Know Your Customer) verification, and a verification saw nearly 80 lakh beneficiaries being weeded out of the scheme, drawing sharp criticism from the Opposition parties. Speaking to reporters ahead of the weekly cabinet meeting, Fadnavis said the state Government had undertaken a verification exercise of beneficiaries after



the scheme was launched and several irregularities came to light. "When the scheme was introduced, women were allowed to self-certify their eligibility, as many did not have sufficient time to submit documents. Subsequently, verification was carried out as the Government expenditure is subject to audit," he

explained. He noted that the scrutiny revealed anomalies, such as women from families of Government employees availing benefits and, in some instances, men filing applications. Fadnavis stated that around 10 lakh beneficiaries were found to have discrepancies, while nearly 14,000 men had applied

under the scheme. The Government cross-checked beneficiary records with the help of income tax, transport and ration card databases to verify eligibility, he said, adding that payments have been halted to ineligible women and those who failed to complete the mandatory e-KYC process. The chief minister further clarified that the Government would not recover money already paid to beneficiaries who were later found ineligible, and only men who fraudulently availed benefits will have to return the money.

Around 1.70 crore women have met all eligibility criteria and will continue to receive assistance under the scheme, he assured. "The scheme will never be shut down. Even today, it is the largest welfare scheme of its kind among states in the country, and it will continue," he said. A senior official

MAHARASHTRA GOVT CLEARS FARM LOAN WAIVER

Mumbai: The Maharashtra cabinet on Tuesday approved a farm loan waiver scheme covering agricultural loans of up to ₹2 lakh, a decision expected to benefit around 56 lakh farmers, sources said. The decision was taken at a cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis ahead of the monsoon season, they said. Farm loan waiver was one of the major promises made by the BJP-led Mahayuti alliance before the 2024

assembly elections. But an official announcement is unlikely at present as the Model Code of Conduct is in force due to the Legislative Council elections, sources said. The scheme will cover more than 65 lakh accounts, and loans worth ₹36,585 crore of nearly 56 lakh farmers are expected to be waived, the sources said. The cabinet also decided to provide an incentive of up to ₹50,000 to farmers who have regularly repaid their crop loans, they said. (PTI)

on Monday informed that the beneficiary count has dropped from 2.4 crore to nearly 1.7 crore after the e-KYC (Know Your Customer) deadline of April 30, but the disqualifications were also linked to non-compliance with eligibility criteria of the scheme launched two years ago. The Government had provided an eight-

month window for beneficiaries to complete their e-KYC to continue getting the monthly stipend of Rs 1,500 under the scheme targeted at poorer women. The opposition parties, however, alleged that the Government had "betrayed" women and was weeding out beneficiaries due to a "severe financial crisis".

No leadership change in Punjab Congress: Baghel

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress general secretary in-charge for Punjab Bhupesh Baghel rejected speculation on Tuesday that the party is mulling a change of leadership in the state and asserted that next year's Assembly polls would be contested by leaders collectively.

Baghel made the assertion after a meeting with the party's top brass at Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge's 10, Rajaji Marg residence here. Besides Kharge, former party chief Rahul Gandhi and Congress general secretary KC Venugopal were also present at the meeting. "A meeting on Punjab was held a few days ago and one was held today as well as the Assembly polls are near. Serious deliberations have been held on the way forward," Baghel told reporters. Asked about the



speculation that a change of guard is being contemplated in the Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee, Baghel said, "I had said a few days ago, there was no discussion on that. The Congress takes everyone along. We will move forward taking everyone along." "This is only speculation in the media. No discussion was held on leadership.... There is no change," he added. On Amarinder Singh Raja Warring, Baghel said he is the PCC chief and the upcoming election in the state will be fought under the leadership of Kharge and Gandhi.

Duty-free cotton imports will devastate small and marginal farmers, claims AIKS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The All India Kisan Sabha (AIKS) condemns the Union Government's decision to suspend the 11 per cent import duty on cotton from June 1 to October 30.

In a joint statement, AIKS President Ashok Dhawale and General Secretary Vijoo Krishnan said this move will put in peril lakhs of cotton farmers and workers who are already being heavily exploited by big business. The NDA Government has capitulated before the big business and sacrificed the interests of the farmers. It is bowing to global and imperial economic pressures, where trade liberalisation and free trade commitments are prioritised over the

protection of Indian farmers and national agricultural imperatives. It is reported that India could import around 40 lakh bales of cotton this duty-free window of 5 months. This is bound to have an adverse impact on domestic cotton prices. It also will force a dependence on imports rather than promote self-reliance.

Cotton prices had risen in recent months (between February and April 2026), but this came after years of unstable prices, rising cultivation costs, and repeated losses faced by farmers. However, these prices fell by 3 per cent soon after the duty exemption was announced, raising fears that farmers will once again bear the burden of protecting indus-

try profits. There is also no clear empirical evidence of a serious cotton shortage in the country.

"In this situation, opening the door to cheaper imports exactly during the sowing season of May-June sends a distressing signal to farmers who are making major investments in seeds, fertilisers, pesticides, and labour, the costs of which are rising hugely. The majority of Indian cotton farmers are small and marginal and receive negligible state support when compared to American or Australian farmers. The suspension of the import duty may also hurt the Cotton Corporation of India (CCI), which has already bought cotton from farmers at MSP," said the statement.

Not a monarchy: Bihar CM on Rabri bungalow row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Sheikhpura

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Tuesday took a veiled dig at the RJD, the main opposition party in the state, which has been indignant over the allotment of the bungalow occupied by former CM Rabri Devi to a minister.

Choudhary referred to the tiff without mentioning the opposition party or its leaders by name and remarked, "It is not a monarchy... The mother wants one house, and the son desires another."

The CM was addressing a gathering at Sahyog camp, recently launched by the state Government to ensure prompt resolution of

people's grievances concerning different departments, in Sheikhpura. Notably, Rabri Devi has been living at 10, Circular Road, refusing to shift to 39, Hardinge Road allotted to her in her capacity as the leader of the opposition in state legislative council. Her son Tejashwi Yadav, the leader of the opposition in the state assembly, is the occupant of 1, Polo Road.

Choudhary, who had been a deputy CM for two years before becoming the first BJP leader to head a Government in Bihar, claimed, "I have never lived in a Government bungalow for the last several years. I have been living in my private house."

New yellow-throated marten found in Assam's Kaziranga

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

A new species of marten has been found in Kaziranga National Park in Assam, the Government said on Tuesday. In a social media post, the Chief Minister's Office said the sighting of the yellow-throated marten in Kaziranga underscores the strength of Assam's conservation model, where protected habitats continue to support remarkable biodiversity and wildlife resilience.

"Under the leadership of HCM Dr. @himantabiswa (Himanta Biswa Sarma), Assam is creating conservation success stories that extend beyond protecting landscapes to nurturing thriving ecosystems," it said.



The Kaziranga National Park & Tiger Reserve is the largest in the Northeast and is thronged by domestic and international tourists in large numbers for its famed one-horned rhinoceros.

Tourist footfall to the forest rose by over 15 per cent in 2025-26 to 4.68 lakh, of which foreign tourist arrivals increased from 17,693 to 30,474 in a year. The Kaziranga National Park, a UNESCO World Heritage Site,

was declared a national park in 1974.

It is inhabited by the world's largest population of one-horned rhinos as well as many mammals, including tigers, elephants, panthers and bears, and thousands of birds. The park is located in Golaghat and Nagaon districts of Assam. It is also located beside the Brahmaputra River in the north and the Karbi Anglong Mountains in the south.



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Editor's
TAKE

Catastrophic heatwaves are killing thousands

Heatwaves are no longer a seasonal extreme. They are a recurring public health emergency, killing tens of thousands

As we are about to celebrate World Environment Day, there is a revelation that is both shocking and unfortunate. Heatwaves in India kill at least 3,000 people every year, and this number can rise to 30,000. It is shocking because the number is so high, and unfortunate because no one takes it seriously, even though these deaths can be avoided if the right steps are taken by the government.

For years, the Indian government has reported roughly 800 heat-related deaths annually. But a reputed research paper has challenged this figure. A peer-reviewed study published last week in Frontiers in Environmental Health suggests the real number may be forty times higher. A single intense heat day, the researchers found, can cause approximately 3,400 excess deaths across India. A prolonged five-day heatwave can cause around 30,000 deaths. Even these figures, the authors caution, are likely an undercount.

The gap between 800 and 30,000 is not a rounding error. It is a policy failure of the first order. What is not counted does not demand a response - and India has, for decades, chosen not to count. The burden falls hardest on those least able to bear it. Five states - Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Gujarat - account for over 60 per cent of projected heatwave mortality while contributing only 29 per cent of national GDP. These are states of outdoor workers, subsistence farmers, construction labourers, and the urban poor, with no air conditioning and no option to stay indoors. This is not bad luck. It is environmental injustice written into policy and inaction.

Heatwave deaths are directly proportional to the economic condition of people and the work they do for a living. Farmers, labourers, and service providers are most at risk, though climate change is the accelerant. South Asia is among the world's most heat-vulnerable regions, and India is leading the pack. Heatwaves that were once rare extremes are becoming routine. Delhi and large parts of north-west India were under a continuous heatwave for over two weeks this May. As global temperatures rise further, events of this severity will occur not once a decade but multiple times a year.

The path forward is clear, even if the political will remains elusive. India must first declare heatwaves a notified national disaster, unlocking emergency finance for the states that need it most. It must overhaul its mortality surveillance so that excess deaths are actually measured, not concealed behind the narrow "heatstroke" category. It must build cooling infrastructure - shaded public spaces, cool roofs, and green cover - in the dense urban wards where the poor have nowhere to retreat. And it must enforce restrictions on outdoor work during extreme heat alerts, protecting the crores of workers for whom stopping work means going hungry. India can definitely take up this challenge. After the Super Cyclone of 1999, which killed thousands of people in Odisha, the state prepared itself for large-scale evacuations. This same urgency and preparedness must guide heatwave management; otherwise, it is going to become an even bigger killer, albeit a silent one.

Tokyo's strategic transformation

Japan is steadily moving away from post-war pacifism, strengthening its military and intelligence capabilities under Sanae Takaichi amid growing concerns over China, Taiwan, and regional security



BHOPINDER SINGH

The term "Tokko" (short for Tokubetsu Koto Keisatsu) was used for the secret police of Imperial Japan from 1911 to 1945. Often compared to the infamous Nazi Gestapo or the Soviet NKVD, it was associated with Japanese militarism, surveillance, and authoritarianism. However, it was dissolved after Japan's defeat in 1945 during Allied occupation reforms. These reforms (Article 9) included the renunciation of war and the discontinuation of traditional Japanese armed forces. Basically, Japan was denied the possession of war-fighting capabilities, infrastructure, or any form of offensive policies or plans.

Since the Cold War, and especially after the 1990s, Japan has reinterpreted Article 9 more flexibly. This led to a more lenient interpretation allowing "collective self-defence", implying that Japan could aid allies under attack in certain situations. Various factors, such as the expanding Chinese footprint, a belligerent North Korea, and even the global terror industry, forced a rethink. Many nationalist Japanese leaders insisted that strict pacifist interpretations were outdated and self-defeating in the evolving strategic environment. The Japanese Self-Defence Forces (JSDF) became increasingly militarised, better trained, and started conducting international exercises and missions.

The Shinzo Abe era transformed that outlook even more aggressively as Chinese ambitions, claims, and maritime activity became increasingly threatening. From ideating the QUAD (Quadrilateral cooperation with China-wary powers such as the USA, India, and Australia) to acquiring long-range strike missiles and converting naval platforms into aircraft carriers, the Japanese consciously started moving away from their original pacifism.

Today, the Prime Minister of Japan, Sanae Takaichi, is widely considered a political protégé and ideological successor of the hardline nationalist Shinzo Abe. China has been concerned by her hawkish rhetoric on security issues, and her recent passage of a bill to strengthen Japanese militarisation through the creation of a "National Intelligence Council" (with a parallel "National Intelligence Bureau" to create a centralised and vertically integrated intelligence system) has unsettled the Chinese leadership considerably.

Chinese concerns were captured by its unofficial mouthpiece, Global Times, which noted: "Even more dangerously, the bill explicitly incorporates 'foreign intelligence activities' into its mandate, shifting Japan's intelligence functions from a domestic security focus to the collection of overseas military and security intelligence - and



even permitting espionage and infiltration operations abroad."

The creation of what is being hailed as "Japan's CIA" is the most significant overhaul of Japan's intelligence structure in more than seventy years. The Americans appear willing to overlook the 1945 conditions they themselves imposed as victors of the Second World War in order to strengthen modern Japan through stronger intelligence integration, faster information-sharing capabilities, and more effective counter-intelligence structures.

The reality of operational difficulties and limitations arising from unilateral military operations overseas, such as those seen in the ensuing US-Iran conflict, has led to serious concerns in Japan about the ability of the US military to intervene successfully should China attack Taiwan. Japan feels increasingly vulnerable to the Chinese threat and realises that it must take greater responsibility for its own security. In Sanae Takaichi, many Japanese see the political intent and determination necessary to change course decisively.

Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi openly framed the bill in existential terms for Japan's future, insisting that "foreign influence operations, including the spread of disinformation, constitute a threat that can shake national security". This argument helped create a situation in which public support stood at 39.1 per cent, while 41.9 per cent remained neutral or undecided, and only 19 per cent opposed the measure.

Clearly, politics, geopolitical shifts, and the perceived wounds of history have evolved, and many Japanese no longer feel burdened by the constitutional constraints imposed in the aftermath of the Second World War.

In the first meeting of the "Expert Meeting on Considering Security from the Perspective of Comprehensive National Strength", Sanae Takaichi further raised the stakes by discussing

higher defence spending and stronger military capabilities. Japan already operates F-35 stealth fighters, Tomahawk missiles, Patriot and Aegis missile-defence systems, Apache attack helicopters, and other advanced platforms. More importantly, it is developing its own hypersonic weapons, long-range missiles, electromagnetic railguns, and a co-developed sixth-generation fighter programme (GCAP).

All this, combined with strong political support, is giving nightmares to Chinese Communist Party strategists, who increasingly realise that Japan has decisively moved beyond its post-war strategic restraint.

Reports emerging from the Ukrainian and Iranian theatres are reinforcing Japanese concerns that military alliances can become strained and unreliable, that industrial capacity and ammunition stockpiles matter enormously, and that nations require substantial indigenous defence capabilities. The ability to hold out longer or deter aggression if American intervention is delayed or uncertain has fuelled right-wing militarist thinking within sections of Japanese politics.

Essentially, Japan believes it needs far greater self-reliant deterrence because the international system has become less reliable.

As Japan's south-western islands are geographically close to Taiwan, China is continuously factoring possible Japanese capabilities and responses into its Taiwan-related strategic calculations. With the acquisition of long-range strike capabilities and growing constitutional confidence, Beijing is increasingly viewing Japan as the central pillar of the US-led Indo-Pacific alliance system aimed at constraining China's rise.

Sanae Takaichi is adding fuel to the fire with statements such as: "Deterrence only works when the other side knows you have the capability and the will to respond."

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

SANAE TAKAICHI IS ADDING FUEL TO THE FIRE WITH STATEMENTS SUCH AS: "DETERRENCE ONLY WORKS WHEN THE OTHER SIDE KNOWS YOU HAVE THE CAPABILITY AND THE WILL TO RESPOND"

The writer is a former Lieutenant Governor of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Puducherry, and a military veteran

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Learning to chant with the heart



AJIT KUMAR BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

I have been chanting God's names for a long time, but mostly inattentively. It is not that I did so intentionally, but it used to happen helplessly. I did not know how to get over this weakness, despite the fact that I knew that I was not reaping the full advantage of chanting.

To my credit, I never gave up chanting, doing it day after day. Finally, my Lord revealed why I was not attentive. The first reason became clear from the following three examples.

Hanumanji had just returned from Lanka, having met Mother Sita and burned Lanka. Obviously, Lord Ramachandra was very pleased. Seeing the Lord's mood, Hanumanji prayed, "O my Lord, please be kind enough to grant me Your unwavering 'bhakti' (devotion), which is the giver of immense 'sukha' (bliss)." (Shri Ramcharitmanas,



Sunderkanda 33) Another example is that of Goswami Tulsidas, who prayed at the beginning of this Kanda, "O Raghukul Shrestha, please grant me Your unmixed bhakti." (SRS 2)

The third example is that of Vibhishanji, who, after meeting Lord Ramachandra, prayed, "O Merciful Lord, please grant me Your pure bhakti." (SRS 48)

Are these famous examples not indicating something? They are: bhakti can only be granted by God and God alone. No one can attain bhakti on his own, which I was trying to do. The second reason is equally compelling. Lord Krishna has cautioned in Verse 7.14: "This Maya (illusory nature) of Mine, consisting of the three 'gunas' (modes), is divine and very difficult to overcome."

What is the Lord cautioning about? Two facts: Maya is created by God and consists of three modes - goodness,

passion, and darkness. These are all-pervading in this material world, and everyone, without exception, is under their influence to varying degrees. (18.40) What happens due to such influence? The mind, which is fickle, forceful, strong, and obstinate (6.34), drags attention away from chanting to somewhere, anywhere. And we are helpless about it.

What is the solution? The Lord gives it: "Those who take shelter in Me alone are able to transcend this Maya." Mark the word alone, because God is the only option.

What is my experience? I have started to seek help before I begin chanting. It works until the mind wanders again. Then I pray for help once more and bring the mind back to chanting. It is working. From a very low percentage of attention, it has risen to a high percentage. I am over the moon about this transformation.

Is not chanting the highest 'yajna' (sacrifice), as described by Lord Krishna in Verse 10.25? This being so, it will yield maximum benefits if done properly, which I am hoping to gain. One more thing I am doing to increase my devotion is to begin thanking my Lord for all the successes that are coming my way. This thankfulness has started to enhance my love for God. Are we not, as small souls, quite helpless and largely ignorant, yet overwhelmed by such mercy? As a matter of fact, it makes all the difference.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a popular columnist

PIC TALK



Farmers harvest paddy crops in a field in Nagaon district, Assam.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

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WHEN GOVERNANCE FAILS, CITIZENS PAY THE PRICE

The collapse of a densely populated building near Saket Metro Station in South Delhi on Saturday, which claimed six lives and injured ten others, is a grim reminder of the urgent need to strengthen urban governance and regulatory oversight. The tragedy was not merely the result of an ageing structure. Reports suggest that the owner had added an additional floor to an already overstretched five-to-seven-storey building in pursuit of higher rental income. Such reckless violations of building norms inevitably increase structural stress and put countless lives at risk.

This incident should not be viewed as a simple accident but as a serious case of negligence with fatal consequences. Unfortunately, similar

unauthorised constructions exist across many parts of Delhi and other Indian cities. Municipal authorities have a responsibility to monitor building activity, groundwater extraction, sewage systems, and utility connections to ensure compliance with safety regulations.

The failure lies not only with individual violators but also with weak enforcement and poor urban planning. Clear limits on plot coverage, building height, and occupancy must be strictly enforced.

As cities continue to expand rapidly, policymakers must prioritise good governance, accountability, and effective regulation to prevent such avoidable tragedies from recurring.

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Telangana: Growth and promise

On June 2, 2026, Telangana celebrated its 12th State Formation Day. Cradled in the heart of the Deccan Plateau, nestled between the valleys of the Godavari and Krishna rivers, Telangana possesses a rich historical legacy dating back to the ancient Ashmaka Janapada, the only southern kingdom among the sixteen Mahajanapadas. The creation of the modern state of Telangana was not simply a result of administrative reorganisation, but rather the culmination of decades-long democratic struggles and the sacrifices of countless martyrs, whose memory has been immortalised through the Gun Park monument. Over the years, the state has emerged as a national model in welfare and development, achieving notable heights in the information technology industry, infrastructure, irrigation, and industrial growth.

The state's ambition of becoming a major economic powerhouse by 2047, however, should be carefully balanced against translating this economic growth into the betterment of marginalised communities. The best tribute to those who preserved Telangana's identity would be a renewed commitment to social justice and inclusive development. Telangana's success will be measured by how effectively the benefits of growth reach every citizen.

VIDYASAGAR REDDY KETHIRI | TELANGANA

A stronger Supreme Court

The Supreme Court's decision to appoint five new judges on June 2, 2026, taking its working strength to 37 against the sanctioned strength of 38, is a welcome step towards strengthening India's judicial system. Particularly encouraging is the elevation of senior advocate Venkita Subramani Mohana, which increases women's representation on the Supreme Court Bench. She becomes only the second woman to be directly elevated from the Bar to the apex court, after Justice Indu Malhotra, and joins Justice BV Nagarathna on the Bench. The appointments reflect the growing role and participation of women in the Indian judiciary and underline the importance of diversity in the justice-delivery system. Equally significant is the increase in the Court's overall strength at a time when the country is grappling with a massive backlog of pending cases. Additional judges can help expedite hearings, reduce delays, and improve access to timely justice for citizens.

The issue assumes greater importance in light of the recent NCRB Prison Statistics Report, which highlights severe overcrowding in Indian prisons, much of it linked to delays in the disposal of cases. Strengthening the Supreme Court is therefore a necessary step towards ensuring a more efficient, inclusive, responsive, and accessible justice system for all citizens.

KIRTI WADHAWAN | KANPUR

Karnataka's leadership transition

The high-stakes leadership transition in Karnataka, which saw DK Shivakumar replace Siddaramaiah as Chief Minister, concluded with surprising outward harmony. However, political analysts have warned that the road ahead for the ruling Congress government may be far from smooth. The underlying tension stems from Siddaramaiah's refusal to accept a Rajya Sabha seat. By remaining active in State politics, the veteran leader has retained considerable influence and continues to be viewed as an alternative power centre within the party.

Siddaramaiah commands a strong mass base and enjoys the loyalty of a significant section of Congress legislators, many of whom were reportedly reluctant to see Shivakumar take over the top post. Consequently, while the transfer of power appeared orderly in public, a quiet rivalry between the two leaders is believed to persist beneath the surface. The real challenge now lies in Shivakumar's ability to consolidate his authority, unite the party, and win the confidence of sceptical legislators. Karnataka faces important governance and developmental challenges that require stability and policy continuity. Whether the current arrangement evolves into effective cooperation or descends into factional conflict remains to be seen in the months ahead.

N SADHASIVA REDDY | BENGALURU

Deadly duty: India’s forest guardians under siege

Doping menace dents India’s global image

As organised criminal networks become more sophisticated and enforcement mechanisms remain weak, the crisis extends beyond the safety of forestry staff to the future of India’s forests, wildlife, water security, and environmental governance



The increasing attacks on front-line forest personnel across India point to a deepening crisis within the country’s environmental governance and forest protection framework. Field staff, including Range Forest Officers, Foresters, and isolated Beat Guards responsible for protecting forests and wildlife habitats, are facing growing violence from organised timber smugglers, illegal encroachment networks, poaching syndicates, and land mafias operating inside forested regions. The increasingly hostile conditions under which forest personnel operate came into renewed focus in May 2026 in the Purnapur Forest Range of Pilibhit district in Uttar Pradesh where, according to reports, two forest personnel narrowly escaped being run over by a tractor-trolley allegedly operated by sheesham timber smugglers, but were cornered and brutally assaulted during the enforcement operation.

Another incident in Madhya Pradesh in the recent past exposed the level of interference in enforcement operations. In Indore district’s Badgonda Forest Range, a state minister, accompanied by supporters, allegedly entered the forest office premises, threatened the on-duty personnel, and forcibly removed an earth-moving machine and tractor-trolley that had been seized for the alleged illegal breaking of forest land. According to reports, the local police station refused to register an FIR against those involved. Instead, disciplinary action was initiated against the enforcement personnel involved in the seizure operation, with the deputy ranger concerned being transferred and subjected to departmental inquiry proceedings. The controversy deepened further after the issue was raised publicly by opposition leaders. Subsequently, when the Chief Conservator of Forests reportedly rejected a revenue department report attempting to classify the land-clearing activity as a non-forest offence, he too was transferred from his post. The broader implications of the episode became evident within weeks. Less than one hundred kilometres away, in Dewas district’s Punjapura Reserve Forest, a forest beat guard was shot dead by a timber smuggler.

One finds that disputes, once considered isolated, have now transformed into coordinated and often violent confrontations, exposing the widening imbalance between poorly equipped forest personnel and highly organised criminal syndicates.

Data and field reports collected over the past five years indicate that such incidents are no longer confined to isolated pockets but are spread across diverse ecological and territorial landscapes in various Indian states. Telangana and Maharashtra have emerged as major hotspots in terms of the volume of reported incidents, followed closely by Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan. Field accounts, departmental records, and testimonies from enforcement personnel also indicate a disturbing pattern in which local political actors are frequently seen intervening in favour of alleged offenders, while pressure groups portray enforcement personnel as being hostile to forest dwellers and tribal communities. In several instances, village gatherings, coordinated protests, and crowd mobilisation have reportedly been used to obstruct enforcement operations and shield organised offenders from legal action. Such resistance is not always spontaneous; in several sensitive forest divisions, officials claim that organised networks deliberately exploit local socio-economic grievances to weaken state intervention and create protective buffers around illegal operations. This has contributed to the emergence of what many enforcement personnel describe as “informal immunity zones”, where the



writ of government becomes increasingly difficult to enforce without substantial police reinforcement.

The misuse of the Forest Rights Act (FRA) to recognise inadmissible forest rights, including management rights to Gram Sabhas, creates governance gaps. Enforcement personnel operating in these contested forest regions face escalating operational risks during anti-encroachment drives and routine forest-protection activities. In several areas, ambiguities surrounding land claims, weak verification mechanisms, administrative intimidation, and political interference severely erode the operational confidence and morale of front-line personnel.

A broader weakening of institutional enforcement capacity within the forest administration has occurred due to limited field infrastructure and chronic staff shortages. Recent data from multiple state-level reports reveal a persistent and severe vacancy crisis across front-line forest-protection cadres. In several major forested states, vacancies in operational posts such as Forest Guards, Foresters, and Range Officers range from nearly one-third to more than half of the sanctioned strength. Odisha has reported vacancies of around 41 per cent in field staff positions, Haryana nearly 54 per cent, Karnataka about 30 per cent, Telangana close to 45 per cent, Madhya Pradesh approximately 30 per cent, Chhattisgarh around 35 per cent, and Jharkhand nearly 55 per cent. Although field foresters are expected to patrol vast, rugged, and remote forest landscapes, vacant posts are often managed locally by assigning the jurisdiction of multiple forest beats or ranges to a single official, resulting in excessively long patrol hours with little operational backup.

Many states have had prolonged recruitment freezes, in some cases extending for more than a decade, followed by mega-recruitment drives aimed at rapidly filling vacancies. The situation is exploited by organised groups that often possess greater mobility, local influence, and financial resources.

Offenders often place local women and economically vulnerable groups at the forefront during confrontations, using them both as human shields and as legal buffers against enforcement action. Although forest departments across several states have begun inducting more women into front-line cadres, criminal syndicates have simultaneously modified their tactics and filed counter-cases, for example under the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, to intimidate and demoralise enforcement staff. A case in Telangana drew national attention after a woman forest officer was allegedly assaulted while performing her official duties in Asifabad district during an operation against illegal activities.

Realising the possibility of retaliatory legal action against enforcement personnel, the Supreme Court of India reportedly stayed the counter-proceedings and directed authorities to provide police protection to women forest officers involved in field duties.

Since forest officials regulate access to natural resources and restrict illegal extraction activities, they often face hostility from some sections of local populations as well as from political interests seeking electoral support through lenient enforcement. Even within the administrative system, forestry personnel often face criticism for strictly enforcing statutory provisions or for denying the diversion of forest land for developmental projects. It is ironic that the

more rigorously foresters protect public forests and ecological territories, the more isolated they become politically and bureaucratically. In a democracy driven by electoral calculations, the job of regulating human activity to save forests and wildlife - constituencies that cannot vote - often leaves forestry personnel resented by sections of the public and neglected by the very institutions they serve.

Although various enforcement institutions have undergone substantial expansion in terms of personnel strength, infrastructure, training, and powers to counter internal security threats, the forest-protection machinery remains structurally understaffed and institutionally weak. It requires strengthening with the latest equipment, rapid-response tracking systems, communication networks, legal support teams, and fast-track courts to ensure the effective prosecution of offenders.

Restoring field morale and enforcement capability is essential if India wishes to secure its ecological frontiers. In the field, strategically combining community participation and rigorous, science-based law enforcement can safeguard not only front-line foresters and forest dwellers but also the invaluable natural heritage of the country.

The government must act to dismantle the politically convenient branding of the forestry sector as “anti-development” or “anti-people”. Forest personnel in the field are not enforcing bureaucratic control; they are risking their lives to defend forests, wildlife habitats, water security, and the ecological systems upon which millions depend. Empowering our ecological protectors can be the ultimate expression of statecraft, as it fundamentally honours the definitive geopolitical truth that ecological integrity is the bedrock of economic vitality and national survival.



MP NATHANAEL

Instances galore of our sportspersons testing positive in dope tests or evading tests have dented our image in the international arena, so much so that the Chair of the Athletics Integrity Unit, David Howman, categorised India as a “consistently extremely high-risk” doping nation and placed it in Category A among the nations where doping is extremely high. Other nations in this category are Russia, Belarus, Kenya, Ethiopia, Nigeria, and Ukraine. This would entail stringent dope-testing measures for all national team athletes. He lamented that the anti-doping efforts in India are “not proportionate to the doping risks.”

With 48 anti-doping rule violations, India was placed second in the world rankings in 2022. In 2023, 63 violations were recorded, with the same ranking. India topped the list of violations the following year with 71 violations and continued to stay on top with 30 violations in 2025. Such gross violations have led to our athletes being viewed with suspicion at international meets. Three of our top athletes had to face embarrassment when they were initially barred from participating in competitions at the Meeting de Limoges in France in April 2024. The decision of the organisers was based on “various controversies related to doping and athletics in India”. It is another matter that they were allowed to participate after the World Athletics Federation intervened.

While stating that India is the biggest producer of PEDs, the World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA) President, Witold Banka, during his visit to New Delhi in April this year, emphasised the need to target the supply chain of banned drugs. Towards this end, he held meetings with Union Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya and senior officers of NADA, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), and other sports officials. Mandaviya assured Mr Banka that the Government is working on criminalising the administration or trafficking of banned substances. Consumption, possession, or administration of banned drugs is a criminal offence in some countries, such as Kenya, where an Indian athlete, Aman Mallik, is serving a three-year jail term since September last year for distributing banned drugs. He was also fined one million Kenyan shillings (approximately Rs 6.9 lakh) for the offence.

Incidentally, Sebastian Sawe, who broke the two-hour mark in the London Marathon recently, hails from Kenya, which earned infamy for doping violations. He was tested 25 times by the Anti-Doping Agency last year and came through all the tests clean. He continues to be subjected to anti-doping tests frequently.

Though Indian sportspersons are governed by the National Anti-Doping (Amendment) Act, 2025, which is based largely on the WADA Code, the consumption, distribution, and trafficking of PEDs have not been criminalised so far. The Union Sports Minister informed the WADA President that work is underway to criminalise doping, which can lead to imprisonment of up to five years and a fine of Rs 2 lakh for selling or trafficking banned substances to any athlete. The Bill is likely to become law during the monsoon session.

The involvement of coaches, trainers, and others associated with sports in administering PEDs cannot be denied. The lure of pelf, power, and jobs on clinching medals at the international level is too intense to be ignored. The risks involved in consuming banned drugs to enhance performance are worth taking for some, and not everyone gets caught. The need has been felt for more laboratories, and we may soon have two more with better staffing, apart from the lone National Dope Testing Laboratory in New Delhi.

Apart from the lure of pelf and jobs, the Arjuna Awards, the Khel Ratna Awards for achievement in sports, and the Dronacharya Award for coaches who train medal winners in the international arena are other attractions that carry with them a host of lifelong benefits. The prestigious Padma awards propel recipients to greater heights. A jail term for anti-doping violations could be a deterrent, though occasions may arise when our top sportspersons get trapped in the web. Irrespective of the stature of the sportspersons involved, stringent action alone can save us from the ignominy of being categorised as “extremely high risk” in anti-doping rule violations.

In the event of an awardee of the Arjuna Award, Khel Ratna Award, Dronacharya Award, or even the Padma awards being found guilty of violating anti-doping rules, the award should be withdrawn by the Government, thereby depriving the violators of the benefits that accrue from the award. Not only the sportspersons but also the coaches would be wary of being caught in any violation of the rules. Any athlete testing positive should not be considered for the conferment of any sports-related award for at least five years from the date of the lifting of the ban.

While we prepare to host the Commonwealth Games in 2030, we have staked our claim to host the Olympics in 2036. For the 2038 Asian Games, South Korea and Mongolia are contesting our bid to host the Games. An Indian delegation that visited the Olympic headquarters in Lausanne in July last year to stake our claim to host the Olympics in 2036 was apprised of our doping record, which could go against us. Banka had warned that “the Olympic Games, World Championships, and major sporting events are not possible without WADA, WADA’s stamp, and WADA’s compliance regulations.”

Until the Sports Ministry comes down heavily on such recalcitrant sportspersons and others associated with sports, we will continue to face the stigma of being a nation with the highest number of violations of WADA regulations.



How Agri stack can catalyse reforms in land revenue administration



DEVESH CHATURVEDI

There have been concerted efforts to modernise land-record administration in the country, which are delivering positive outcomes. However, there are still several challenges. States with robust, updated records are at various

stages of digitalisation. In many other states, land ownership is still recorded in the names of ancestors. In major parts of the North-Eastern states, there is an absence of conventional records of rights due to the practice of community ownership. Even though there is a widespread practice of sharecropping and informal leasing across the country, there is reluctance to record the same in many states due to the legacy of laws related to adverse possession. National Crime Records Bureau data also indicate that land-related disputes are one of the major motives for crimes in rural areas. The Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) in agriculture offers a way forward to meet these challenges. To transform governance and policy implementation in the agriculture sector, the Union Government launched the Digital Agriculture Mission (DAM) in 2024. One of the key components of the mission is to establish a DPI for agriculture. The building block of this infrastructure is Agri Stack, comprising three core registries - farm, farmer, and crop sown. Farm Registry is a database of geo-ref-

erenced plots with a unique Farm ID. Each agricultural plot is provided with a unique Farm ID for identification. Simultaneously, each farmer owning agricultural land is provided with a unique Farmer ID, which, at the back end, will have complete details of each plot owned by the farmer, along with the share/extent of the farmer in that plot. The Farmer Registry is dynamically linked to the digitised records of rights of the State Revenue Department, ensuring that changes in the records of rights due to sale, inheritance, etc., are automatically updated in the Farmer Registry. The third pillar is the Crop Sown Registry, with details of crops sown on each plot for each crop cycle, developed on the basis of the Digital Crop Survey. The survey is undertaken immediately after the sowing seasons. Discipline in the survey is ensured as it is mandatory for the surveyor to physically enter the plot of land being surveyed to record the crop sown.

Agri Stack is being developed as a collaborative exercise between the Central Government and the State/UT Governments while ensuring that it is credible, standardised, and interoperable across the country, both at the federal and state levels.

As of May15, 2026, more than 9.50 crore Farmer IDs had been created across the country. The Digital Crop Survey was conducted in more than 30 crore plots across 648 districts, covering 24 states during the Rabi season of 2025-26.

Agri Stack is being developed primarily to empower farmers to seamlessly avail themselves of various scheme benefits, and not as an alternative to land records or certificates of land ownership and crops sown. The dynamic linkage with



records of rights ensures the authenticity of the Farmer Registry. This arrangement of a separate registry linked to records of rights would ensure that farmers are less hesitant in digitally authorising, in the Farmer Registry, their relatives, sharecroppers, and leaseholders (formal or informal) to avail themselves of scheme benefits such as MSP procurement, procurement of fertiliser, crop insurance, or even crop loans.

The flexible architecture of Agri Stack and its potential to be used for availing entitlement-based benefits have catalysed reforms in land-revenue administration and the process of modernisation and digitalisation of land-record administration in several states and Union Territories. One immediate outcome is that the geo-referencing of revenue cadastral maps is being completed within a highly compressed timeframe. Wherever cadastral maps are not available, the state machinery is approaching village elders and searching through record rooms to obtain copies of the maps. Some states have even undertaken survey operations to prepare cadastral maps afresh. State and UT administrations have also moved quickly in recording the share of landholders in plots that

have multiple owners, without the necessity of filing a partition suit. The traditional manually driven *girdavari* or *partial* system was prone to errors, with delayed consolidated results, and therefore had limited utility for policymakers. The Digital Crop Survey under Agri Stack is steadily replacing this manual system and becoming a single source of truth, ensuring credibility through the timely and accurate capture of crops sown. Feedback from farmers and the appeal system ensure transparency, with greater involvement of farmers in the process. With Farmer ID becoming a prerequisite for availing various scheme benefits in states, additional pressure is being placed on lower-level officials in the land-revenue administration to record inheritance immediately after the death of a landholding farmer. In states such as Bihar, Jharkhand, Odisha, and Assam, land is often still recorded in the names of ancestors. To address this, current owners can obtain land inheritance certificates, enabling Farmer ID generation while land records are updated. This is helping revenue authorities record actual owners and cultivators, improving access to credit and welfare benefits. The Farmer Registry has also accelerated land-records updation in several states.

In several states in the North-Eastern region of the country where there is community ownership, the absence of surveys to establish individual ownership has led to the sub-optimal uptake of agricultural welfare schemes such as subsidised agricultural credit and crop insurance. The mission has initiated the process of a digitised solution utilising satellite-based imagery to identify existing plot boundaries and develop geo-referenced maps

without the need for manual survey operations. Local authorities identify the actual cultivator of each plot and assign unique plot numbers. Farmer IDs are then generated and the Digital Crop Survey undertaken based on the maps so developed. These are not substitutes for land records but a credible alternative for recording the owner/cultivator for availing entitlement-based scheme benefits. Agri Stack has the potential to ensure a regime that protects agricultural land owned by farmers against fraudulent sales and transactions. If the states so desire, they can notify services related to the linkage of landholdings with Aadhaar numbers in the records of rights by notifying the same under Section 4(4)(b)(ii) of the Good Governance Rules under the Aadhaar Act. This notification enables the embedding of the Aadhaar number of the owner in the land owned, with the voluntary consent of the farmer. Thereafter, any fraudulent transaction in the Sub-Registrar’s office becomes detectable and preventable, as it can be carried out only after the recorded tenure-holder has been biometrically verified during the registration of any sale deed or will. This reform has the potential to drastically reduce land disputes and crimes related to land.

The DPI is enabling transformational reforms in welfare delivery and land-record administration, empowering farmers and strengthening the security of their landholdings.

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3 get 10-yr jail for throwing woman from second floor

A Delhi court sentenced three members of a family to 10 years of rigorous imprisonment for attempting to murder a woman by throwing her from a second-floor balcony following a dispute over dowry demands, leaving her permanently paralysed below the waist.

The convicts, Amir Khan, his mother Nasrin and brother Sonu alias Firoz, were sentenced on June 1 by Additional Sessions Judge Vishal Singh's court at Saket Court. All three were found guilty under Sections 307 (attempt to murder) and 34 (common intention) of the Indian Penal Code in 2022. Amir Khan and Nasrin were also convicted under Section 498A for cruelty and harassment related to dowry demands.

According to the police, the case stemmed from FIR No. 151/2022, registered at KalindiKunj police station on the victim's complaint. She alleged that she had been subjected to persistent harassment and cruelty by her husband and in-laws over dowry. Investigators found that on 14 February 2022, an argument linked to dowry demands escalated at the family's residence. The three accused allegedly acted together to throw the woman from a second-floor balcony.

She suffered severe spinal injuries in the fall, resulting in permanent paralysis below her waist. Police said the investigation involved the collection of medical, documentary, and scientific evidence, the inspection of the crime scene, the seizure of relevant exhibits, and the recording of statements from key witnesses.



NEET row: Judicial custody of 5 accused extended till June 15

A Delhi court on Tuesday extended the judicial custody of five accused in the NEET paper leak case till June 15.

Special Judge Ajay Gupta allowed the CBI's plea seeking extension of judicial custody of Mangilal Khatik, Vikas Biwal, Dinesh Biwal, all three arrested from Jaipur; Yash Yadav, arrested from Gurugram; and Dhnanjay Lokhande, arrested from Ahilyanagar in Maharashtra.

Earlier on May 20, they had been sent to judicial custody till June 2.

Meanwhile, counsel for accused Yadav said that the court had allowed his client's plea seeking books to prepare for the rescheduled NEET exam.

On Monday, physics lecturer Manisha Sanjay Hawaldar, paediatrician Dr Manoj Shirure and physics teacher Tejas Harshadkumar Shah were sent to 14 days of judicial custody. The CBI has arrested 13 accused persons in the case.



SC to examine sacking Govt staff for hidden qualification

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Can a Government employee be terminated from service for suppressing information about possessing higher qualifications than the prescribed degree for the job?

The Supreme Court on Tuesday agreed to examine a Telangana High Court verdict, which upheld the Centre's decision to terminate the service of a Scheduled Tribe person who had allegedly suppressed the information of being 'intermediate pass' than the prescribed 'tenth pass' criteria required for the job of 'work assistant'.

A bench of justices PS Narasimha, Aravind Kumar and Shree Chandershekar issued notice to the Centre on a plea of Pawar Subhash, who has challenged the order of the High Court dated November 27, 2025.



"This judgement is prima facie wrong. We will examine the judgement. There is already a Supreme Court judgement which says that higher qualification cannot be a ground for disqualification," the bench told the counsel appearing for Subhash.

The High Court in its verdict had noted that the petitioner had applied for the post of 'work assistant' for which the prescribed qualification was 'tenth pass' and did not dis-

CJI administers oath of office to 5 new SC judges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Tuesday administered the oath of office to five new judges of the Supreme Court, taking the strength of judges at the top court to 37, the highest ever.

The CJI administered the oath of office to justices Sheel Nagu, Shree Chandrashekar, Sanjeev Sachdeva, Arun Palli, and V Mohana. The swearing-in ceremony was held in the apex court premises.

The strength of judges at the apex court will now be 37, one short of the upgraded sanctioned strength of 38.

The Centre on Monday cleared the appointment of Justice Nagu, the chief justice of the Punjab and Haryana High Court, Justice Chandrashekar, the chief justice of the Bombay High Court, Justice Sachdeva, the chief justice of the Madhya Pradesh High Court, Justice

Palli, the chief justice of the Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh High Court, and senior advocate Mohana as top court judges.

The Government last month promulgated an ordinance amending a law to increase the sanctioned strength of the apex court from 34 to 38, including the CJI. Two sitting Supreme Court judges — Justice Pankaj Mithal and Justice JK Maheshwari — are set to retire on June 16 and June 28.

The five new names were recommended by the apex court Collegium on May 27 and the appointments came through in four days.

Justice Mohana became only the second woman in the country to be directly elevated to the apex court from the Bar after Justice Indu Malhotra in 2018.

She will be one of the two serving women judges in the Supreme Court, the other one being Justice BV Nagarathna, who has been a judge at the



THE CJI ADMINISTERED THE OATH OF OFFICE TO JUSTICES SHEEL NAGU, SHREE CHANDRASHEKHAR, SANJEEV SACHDEVA, ARUN PALLI, AND V MOHANA

top court since August 31, 2021. Justice Nagarathna will become the Chief Justice of India in September 2027. She will be the CJI for more than a month. Born on January 1,

1965, Justice Nagu was enrolled as an advocate in October 1987.

He was appointed an additional judge of the Madhya Pradesh High Court on May 27,

Twisha case: Husband, mother-in-law get judicial custody till June 16

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

A special CBI court in Bhopal on Tuesday sent Samarth Singh, husband of deceased software professional Twisha Sharma, and his mother, retired judge Giribala Singh, to 14 days of judicial custody in connection with the high-profile death case. The court remanded both accused to Bhopal Central Jail until June 16 after the CBI, whose police custody had ended, chose not to seek further remand.

During the hearing, a verbal exchange took place between lawyers representing the two sides. Giribala Singh alleged that counsel for Twisha's family had assaulted her son during proceedings in Jabalpur. The allegation was rejected by the lawyer, who said CCTV footage from the court premises could verify the facts.

The CBI is continuing its investigation and has begun matching the statements of the accused with available evidence. Both Samarth Singh and Giribala Singh have denied allegations of assault and evidence tampering, maintaining that their relationship with Twisha was normal. Investigators recently conducted a reconstruction of events and are examining material seized during the probe.



Model-actor Twisha Sharma's husband, Samarth Singh being produced before the Bhopal district court on Tuesday

A key focus of the investigation is the handling of the ligature belt allegedly used in the incident. Sources familiar with the probe said the belt was not secured immediately in accordance with forensic protocols. Instead, it reportedly remained in the possession of the investigating officer for nearly two days before being sent to the Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL). The belt was also not deposited at AIIMS during the post-mortem process, raising questions about the preservation of crucial evidence.

While no action has yet been taken against the officer concerned, the CBI is preparing to issue notices for questioning and may summon other individuals linked to the investigation. Twisha's family has consistently disputed the initial suicide theory, alleging

foul play and questioning why the ligature belt was not properly preserved as evidence. The subsequent revelation regarding its custody and handling has intensified scrutiny of the investigation.

Investigators are also examining Twisha's professional and personal circumstances. Preliminary findings indicate that she had not received regular salary payments from her employer for the previous six to seven months.

According to counsel representing Twisha's family, the CBI informed the court that statements of several key witnesses are yet to be recorded and forensic analysis of seized digital devices remains underway.

Depending on the findings, the agency may seek further custodial interrogation of the accused at a later stage.

Delhi HC protects personality rights of actor Varun Dhawan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has protected the personality rights of actor Varun Dhawan and restrained the unauthorised use of his name, image and other attributes by third parties for commercial or personal gain, and the creation of AI-generated deepfake images and derogatory content.

Justice Jyoti Singh, in an interim order passed on the film star's lawsuit, said Dhawan is a "celebrated actor" and has the "right to protect his name, likeness, voice and image" from unauthorised use by third parties.

The court ordered the defendants and online platforms to take down the offending content.

In case of any fresh content that infringes Dhawan's personality rights, the social media platforms, including YouTube and Meta, have been directed to



take them down within 36 hours of communication, it added.

In the order dated May 29, the court said that Dhawan holds a registered trademark for his name and signatures, which gives him the statutory right to its exclusive use, and the unauthorised sale of merchandise using his name, image, likeness and other elements of his persona to make commercial gain is unlawful.

It also said content por-

traying him in inappropriate scenarios with female co-stars was extremely abusive and derogatory, which was causing irreparable damage to his immense goodwill and reputation.

"Plaintiff is entitled to protection against dissemination of pornographic content as well as AI-generated images portraying him in an inappropriate scenario. Such distasteful content is harming and damaging the reputation of the Plaintiff

THE COURT SAID THE UNAUTHORISED SALE OF MERCHANDISE USING HIS DHAWAN NAME, IMAGE, LIKENESS AND OTHER ELEMENTS OF HIS PERSONA TO MAKE COMMERCIAL GAIN IS UNLAWFUL

and may mislead the public into believing what is depicted may be true," observed the court.

Dhawan's senior counsel contended that there were third parties who were infringing his personality and publicity rights by falsely and unauthorisedly offering bookings for his appearances and performances, selling unauthorised merchandise bearing his name, face, image, signature/ autograph and the like, creating deepfake images and hosting pornographic content by using

his name and image.

"Defendants No 1 to 3, 5 to 8, 10 to 13 and 15... are restrained till the next date of hearing from violating Plaintiff's Personality/ Publicity Rights by utilising and/ or in any manner directly or indirectly, using or exploiting or misappropriating Plaintiff's: (a) name Mr. Varun Dhawan; (b) image; (c) voice; and (d) likeness and/ or any other attribute of his persona, without his authorisation, for any commercial and/ or personal gain, through the use of technology including but not limited to Artificial Intelligence, Generative Artificial Intelligence, Machine Learning, Deepfakes, AI Chatbots, Face Morphing and/ or any other mediums and formats," the court ordered.

The court issued summons to the defendants in the lawsuit and listed it for further proceedings on August 5.



THE SC ALSO DIRECTED THAT DISCIPLINARY AND LEGAL ACTION BE INITIATED AGAINST ALL IDENTIFIED 118 SERVING AND RETIRED GOVERNMENT SERVANTS WHO ARE FOUND TO BE ENCROACHERS

mental governance and the constitutional obligation of the State to preserve and protect ecologically sensitive regions, fragile ecosystems, and critically endangered wildlife for the benefit of present and future generations," the bench said.

It delivered its verdict on May 29 on a plea raising issues, including those concerning preservation of reserve forests, wildlife sanctuaries and tiger reserves in Tamil Nadu.

It noted that as per a July 2025 interim report of the

Central Empowered Committee (CEC), the Agasthyamalai ecological landscape covers 3,500.36 square km encompassing several districts of Tamil Nadu and Kerala.

It noted that as per report a submitted by the district magistrate of Theni district, a total of 4,601 encroachers have occupied 5,072.653 hectares of land in reserved forests across the district and thus far, only 1.8 percent of the total encroached forest land has been reclaimed.

Saket building collapse: Delhi court sends owner to three-day police custody

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Tuesday sent the owner of a multi-storey building, which collapsed in south Delhi's Saket area killing six people, to three days' police custody.

Judicial Magistrate First Class Nirmala Singh was hearing the Delhi Police plea seeking five days of custody of the 71-year-old building owner, Karambir Sejwal. She granted three days' custody of the accused for further investigation into the incident.

Seeking custody, the police told the court that Sejwal was the

owner of the building and custodial interrogation was required to verify ownership records and trace other accused persons who were absconding.

The investigating officer told the court that a previous builder had also allegedly carried out illegal construction at the site and that Sejwal knew his identity. The police said they wanted to track down the builder and ascertain the circumstances that led to the collapse.

"He's the owner of the building... we need to see the ownership record. Apart from him, other accused are absconding.

"The previous builder also did



illegal construction. The owner knows his name... we want to track him down," the police said in the court.

Opposing the plea, Sejwal's counsel Rajiv Mohan argued that the case was registered under Section 105 of the BNS, dealing with culpable homicide not amounting to murder, and contended that no evidence had yet emerged against his client.

The building collapsed on May 30, triggering a massive rescue operation that continued for several hours.

According to the police, the structure housed a coaching insti-

tute, cafes and offices while construction work was underway on its uppermost floor at the time of the collapse.

Six people were killed and eight others injured in the incident. The police arrested Sejwal on Monday as part of the investigation and are probing whether structural violations or unauthorised construction contributed to the collapse.

Meanwhile, for students living in the Saidulajab area of the Capital, Saturday's multi-storey building collapse has left behind lingering fears about safety with worried parents and relatives checking on them constantly and

urging them to move elsewhere.

The area in Saket is a bubbling students' hub filled with paying guests, hostels and student rental homes along with cafes and canteens. The building, which came crashing down on Saturday, housed a coaching institute, cafes and offices, and construction work was underway on its uppermost floor at the time of the collapse.

"Three days have passed since the collapse, but my family's fear has not gone. I stay in the adjacent lane and I still remember the sound of the structure coming down," said Ankit Kumar, a 26-year-old medical aspirant.

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Crude oil futures slip on US, Iran ceasefire uncertainty



Crude oil prices fell marginally to ₹8,697 per barrel in futures trade on Tuesday, tracking losses in global benchmarks even as investors remained cautious over the fluid geopolitical situation involving the US and Iran.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), the most-traded June contract slipped by ₹39, or 0.45 per cent, to ₹8,697 per barrel in a business turnover of 9,045 lots. The July contract also weakened, falling ₹70, or 0.82 per cent, to ₹8,466 per barrel in 2,512 lots.

Analysts said market sentiment was weighed down by uncertainty after diplomatic efforts aimed at resolving the crisis faced repeated hurdles, raising concerns over the outlook for global oil demand and supply.

Meanwhile, US President Donald Trump on Monday indicated that Israel and Hezbollah had agreed to halt hostilities, raising hopes that a broader regional conflict could be avoided.

Trump in a social media post said that he spoke to Israel's Prime Minister, Benjamin Netanyahu, and representatives of Hezbollah and both agreed that "all shooting will stop". However, market participants remained wary as attacks from both sides were reported after the announcement, while Israeli and Hezbollah officials cast doubt on the durability of the arrangement.

"This has become a common pattern in recent months, and there are still plenty of mixed messages. President Trump says that negotiations are continuing. As a result, oil prices continue to be whipsawed by quickly changing headlines," Warren Patterson, Head of Commodities Strategy at ING Think said.

Globally, Brent oil futures for August contract fell 1 per cent at \$94.03 per barrel, while West Texas Intermediate for July delivery slipped 1.10 per cent to \$91.15 per barrel. (PTI)

Chouhan reviews monsoon progress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Tuesday reviewed the progress of southwest monsoon and directed officials to provide timely farm advisories and maintain better coordination with states to tackle the potential impact of El Nino on kharif crops.

The Government is on "alert mode", Chouhan said, asking officials to maintain constant check on monsoon status. "Ensure better coordination with States and take prompt action," Chouhan told officials in the meeting. He also asked them to provide timely advisories and essential assistance to farmers, an official statement said. Measures to safeguard farmers' interests and mitigate the impact on kharif crops were discussed in detail, it said.



Officials from all departments and agencies concerned were present in the meeting. The southwest monsoon is expected to onset over Kerala around June 4, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said on Tuesday. Typically, rains arrive in Kerala around June 1, marking the beginning of the southwest monsoon season (June-September). In its latest outlook, the

IMD has forecast southwest monsoon to be about 90 per cent of normal, flagging a below-normal season and heightened crop-risk pressure, particularly if El Nino conditions strengthen later in the season. The southwest monsoon, which contributes 70-75 per cent of India's annual rainfall, is critically important for kharif (summer) crops like paddy as 51 per cent of the net sown area is unirrigated and rain-fed.

Trade pact with Oman strengthens India's energy security: Experts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The free trade agreement with Oman will strengthen India's energy and economic security in the volatile Gulf region, according to experts. The trade agreement between the two countries was implemented on June 1. "First, it strengthens India's energy and economic security in a volatile region. Oman has long been one of India's most reliable partners in the Gulf," think tank CRF President Shishir Priyadarshi said. He added that as India remains heavily dependent on imported oil, gas and petrochemicals, deeper economic integration with Oman helps create a more stable and predictable framework for a relationship that is vital to India's energy

needs. The US-Iran war and the subsequent closure of the Strait of Hormuz have led to disruptions in supply chains across sectors, including agricultural goods and energy products. Oman can also serve as a manufacturing, logistics and re-export hub for Indian businesses to West Asia. "So, the significance of this free trade agreement is larger than bilateral trade numbers. It is about securing critical economic relationships, creating new opportunities for the Indian industry, and signalling that India intends to be a leading player in shaping the next phase of global trade and connectivity," Priyadarshi added. Echoing similar views, International trade expert and Hi-Tech Gears Chairman Deep Kapuria said the operationalisation of the



First, it strengthens India's energy and economic security in a volatile region. Oman has long been one of India's most reliable partners in the Gulf

—CRF PRESIDENT SHISHIR PRIYADARSHI

trade pact will help India in expanding its market share not only in Oman but also in the entire West Asia region.

"With zero-duty market access for all its exports to Oman from the date of entry of this trade deal, along with streamlined regulatory pro-

cedures, reduced compliance requirements, Indian exporters are well positioned to expand their presence across multiple product segments in Oman," he said. He added that though Oman is a relatively small market, it offers export opportunities across all key sectors such as engineering, pharma, agriculture, food processing, marine products, textiles, Chemicals, electronics, Gems and Jewellery among others. The trade pact with Oman holds strategic significance for India, as much of Muscat's coastline lies outside the Strait of Hormuz, unlike other Gulf nations, enabling it to remain a reliable trade and energy gateway for India even during regional conflicts, disruptions, or geopolitical instability, think tank GTRI said.

No intention to hike retail prices: Mother Dairy Chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Mother Dairy, which hiked milk prices by ₹2 per litre last month, on Tuesday said there is no "intention" currently to further increase the retail price in view of comfortable supply situation. Mother Dairy, one of the leading fresh milk suppliers in India, sells around 55 lakh litre of milk per day across many States. On May 14, the company increased consumer prices of its liquid milk variants by ₹2 per litre to partly offset rising input costs. At a press conference, Mother Dairy Chairman Meenesh Shah said the company increased milk prices last month after a gap of one year because of the increased input cost. About any plans to increase rates further, he said, "I do not foresee any increase. But then if there is any increase in input cost and we are in a situation where we are unable to meet our ends, we will see."

"But, as of now, we have no intention to increase the consumer price," said Shah, who is also the Chairman of National Dairy Development Board (NDDB). Mother Dairy is a wholly owned subsidiary of the NDDB. He asserted that the milk supply situation and procurement of milk from farmers in the country are comfortable now. On concerns related to supply of



MOTHER DAIRY CHAIRMAN MEENESH SHAH

I DO NOT FORESEE ANY INCREASE. BUT THEN IF THERE IS ANY INCREASE IN INPUT COST AND WE ARE IN A SITUATION WHERE WE ARE UNABLE TO MEET OUR ENDS, WE WILL SEE

fodder in view of IMD's forecast of below normal monsoon, Shah said there should not be any problem in the total availability of fodder. He said there could be problem in some states, but that could be compensated by other parts of the country. Shah said the country's milk production is expected to rise 4-6 per cent this fiscal year from around 250 million tonnes in the previous year. The NDDB Chairman noted that the growth in milk production annually is in line with rising consumption and asserted that there would not be any issue in meeting this growing demand for dairy products over the next 10-15 years.

Shah said the Government has taken various measures to boost milk production through improvement of animal health and their productivity. More dairy cooperative societies are being formed across the country. Last month, Mother Dairy had said the "revision in prices has been necessitated in view of the sustained increase in farmer procurement prices, of around 6 per cent over the past one year, despite continued efforts to limit the impact on consumers". Mother Dairy had said the price revision represents only a partial pass through of increased costs. It passes on nearly 75-80 per cent of its milk sales realisation to farmers.

West Bengal Govt holds pre-Budget talks with industry associations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The West Bengal finance department on Tuesday held a pre-Budget consultation meeting with industry chambers and trade associations, with stakeholders pitching for measures to boost investment, ease of doing business and infrastructure development ahead of the first budget of the BJP's maiden Government in the State. The meeting, chaired by Additional Chief Secretary (Finance) Prabhat Kumar Mishra, was attended by representatives of major industry bodies including the Bharat Chamber of Commerce, CREDAI, ASSOCHAM, CII and several other chambers and trade organisations. Senior State Government officials, including Commissioner of State Tax Khalid Anwar, were present at the meeting. According to finance department sources, the Government sought sug-



ISSUES RAISED DURING THE DISCUSSIONS INCLUDED INVESTMENT INCENTIVES, DEVELOPMENT OF THE HALDIA INDUSTRIAL REGION, PROMOTION OF SOLAR ENERGY PROJECTS

gestions from industry and trade bodies before finalising the Budget proposals. "The meeting was primarily consultative in nature. Representatives from various chambers and trade bodies shared their views and expectations from the upcoming Budget across sectors," a finance department source told PTI. Issues raised during the

discussions included investment incentives, development of the Haldia industrial region, promotion of solar energy projects, simplification of trade licence procedures, strengthening of the single-window clearance mechanism, solid waste management, and concerns relating to the real estate and construction sectors, the source said.

RBI likely to maintain status quo in June, hike rates twice in FY27: Economists

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is likely to keep the benchmark repo rate unchanged in the June monetary policy review, according to a PTI poll of economists and treasury heads. Most of the respondents expect the Central Bank to resume policy tightening later in FY27 amid mounting inflation risks. Of the respondents surveyed, 11 expect the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) to maintain the status quo on rates in the upcoming policy to be announced on Friday, while four foresee a 0.25 per cent hike. "Pause because headline inflation remains below the 4 per cent target. The RBI has

policy space to wait to see the second round impact on inflation from the fuel price hike. Flexible inflation target provides policy space to look through the first round impact of supply side shocks," said Gaura Sengupta, economist at IDFC First Bank. The MPC will meet between June 3 and June 5 to decide on the policy rates. The Central Bank has reduced the repo rate by 1.25 per cent since last year to aid growth. Economists attributed the likelihood of a near-term pause to the RBI's preference to assess the impact of recent fuel price increases and geopolitical developments before taking further policy action. Despite expectations of a pause in June, the majority of respondents see the policy



rate moving higher over the course of FY27. Most participants expect at least two rate hikes during the fiscal year, while some anticipate more than two increases if inflationary pressures intensify. Only a handful expect a single rate hike. "We now think the MPC is likely to begin hiking from

the June meeting, as domestic inflation risks are rising, alongside higher global yields; a few Asian central banks have already delivered surprise hikes. Our FY27 rate hike forecasts face upside risk of 0.25-0.50 per cent if pressures on commodity prices, rupee sustain," said Anubhuti Sahay,

RBI DATA	
● Most of the respondents expect the Central Bank to resume policy tightening later in FY27 amid mounting inflation risks	5 to decide on the policy rates
● The RBI has policy space to wait to see the second round impact on inflation from the fuel price hike	● The Central Bank has reduced the repo rate by 1.25 per cent since last year to aid growth
● The MPC will meet between June 3 and June	● The poll showed a broad consensus that the RBI is likely to revise its inflation projections upward in the upcoming policy review

head, India economic research at Standard Chartered Bank, India. The poll showed a broad consensus that the RBI is likely to revise its inflation projections upward in the upcoming policy review. Most respondents expect FY27 consumer price inflation

estimates to be raised to around 4.9-5.5 per cent, following the rise in global crude oil prices and the recent increase in domestic petrol and diesel prices. ICRA chief economist Aditi Nayar said inflation could rise to around 5 per cent in June as higher fuel prices begin

feeding into consumer prices, although the extent of second-round effects remains uncertain. Several respondents said the Central Bank may prefer to wait for greater clarity on whether the inflationary impact proves to be temporary or persistent. Alongside higher inflation projections, many respondents expect the RBI to marginally lower its FY27 GDP growth forecast to reflect the risks posed by elevated energy prices and uncertainty stemming from geopolitical tensions in West Asia. While the expected revision to growth projections is seen as modest, economists believe higher input costs and weaker global demand conditions could weigh on economic activity if crude oil prices remain elevated

for a prolonged period. On liquidity, most respondents do not expect any major measures in the June policy, though they said the RBI is likely to reiterate its commitment to maintaining adequate liquidity conditions in the banking system and ensuring money market rates remain aligned with the policy corridor. Some respondents also expect the Central Bank to review administrative and regulatory measures related to the rupee and foreign exchange market, while maintaining its focus on orderly market conditions. Others believe no significant action may be required, given the expected boost to system liquidity from the RBI dividend transfer.



THE INCREASE IN TRANSPORT COSTS WILL HAVE STRONGEST IMPACT ON FOOD CATEGORIES THAT RELY ON LOGISTICS NETWORKS, INCLUDING DAIRY PRODUCTS, TEA, COFFEE, FRUITS, PULSES, SPICES, EGGS

impact these freight cost structures and feed into prices across supply chains in the coming months," it said. The increase in transport costs is expected to have the strongest impact on food categories that rely heavily on logistics networks, including dairy products, tea, coffee, fruits, pulses, spices, eggs, meat and fish. Combined with a favourable base effect fading, this could accelerate food inflation in the coming quarters.

OYO-PARENT PRISM SECURES SEBI'S NOD TO LAUNCH ₹6,650-CR IPO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prism, the parent firm of global travel tech unicorn Oyo, has secured clearance from markets regulator Sebi to raise ₹6,650 crore through its initial public offering (IPO), people familiar with the development said on Tuesday. The proposed public offering is expected to value the company at \$7-8 billion, they added. Oyo's parent entity Prism filed the preliminary IPO papers with Sebi in December 2025 through the confidential route.



The filing followed shareholders' approval at an Extraordinary General Meeting (EGM) held on December 20, 2025, where the company received consent to raise up to ₹6,650 crore through a fresh issue of equity shares. Prism opted for the confidential pre-filing route, which allows the company to engage with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) for initial feedback on its draft document without it being publicly disclosed. As the next step, the company is expected to file a public Updated Draft Red Herring Prospectus (UDRHP-1) in early July, which will be open for public comments for 21 days, people familiar with the development said. They said that Prism is currently evaluating market conditions and broader listing timelines while preparing to file its UDRHP-1.

ANANTHAPURAM II POWER TRANSMISSION LIMITED (CIN: U42202DL2025PLC450695)		
Regd. Office: 137, Avtar Enclave, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110063, Ph: No: +91 11 4508 8679, Email: head.powertrans@scegroup.co.in		
PUBLIC NOTICE		
Ananthapuram II Power Transmission Limited having its registered office at Plot No. 137, Avtar Enclave, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110063 CIN: U42202DL2025PLC450695 has applied to the Government of India to confer upon him all the powers under section 164 of the electricity act, 2003 for the placing of electric lines or electrical plant for the transmission of electricity or for the purpose of telephonic or telegraphic communications necessary for the proper coordination of works which telegraph authority possess under the Indian telegraph Act, 1885 with respect to the placing of telegraph lines and posts for the purpose of a telegraph established or maintained, by the Government or to be so established or maintained and will undertake the survey, construction, installation, inspection, erection and other works to be followed by commissioning, operation, maintenance and other work for the following transmission schemes.		
Name of the Transmission Scheme: Integration of Ananthapuram-II REZ-Phase-II (3 GW)		
Works Covered under the Scheme: 1. Establishment of 3x1500 MVA, 765/400 kV CN'Halli Station with 2x330 MVAr (765 kV) bus reactors 2. Augmentation of Ananthapuram-II Pooling Substation 3. Ananthapuram-II PS – CN'Halli 765 kV D/c line 4. LILO of one circuit of Talaguppa - Neelmangala 400 kV D/c line at CN'Halli 5. LILO at CN'Halli of already LILOed section of one circuit of Talaguppa - Neelmangala 400 kV line at Hassan The above Transmission Project has already received prior approval of Ministry of Power, Government of India under section 68(1) of Electricity Act, 2003 vide Letter No. 25-17/85/2025-PG, Dated: 15th Sept, 2025 The transmission lines covered under the scheme will pass through, over, around, and between the following villages, towns and cities		
I. Ananthapuram-II PS – CN'Halli 765 kV D/c line		
S. No.1 Tehsil/Taluka : Chiknayakanahalli (Chiknayakanahalli)	District: Tumakuru	State: Karnataka
Village Names		
Shettykere (Shettikere), Madhihalli (Madihalli), Manchandra (Manchasandra), Thammadihalli, Benakanahalli, Hesarahalli, Dibbadahalli, Kuppuru, Kurubarahalli, Anekatte, Yarehalli, Aralikere (Aralekere), Pura, Muddhenahalli (Muddenahalli), Maraluhallada Kaval (M H Kaval), Gaurasagara (Govrasagara), Gottigenahalli, Dasihalli (Dasechalli), Dagganahalli (Diggenahalli), Thagachikatte (Tagacheghatta), Madapura, Kamalapura, Bevinahalli, Matthighatta (Mattighatta), Chattasandra, Davanadahoshahalli (Davanada Hosahalli), Malligere, Mallenahalli, Upparahalli, Bangaragere, Kengalapura, Ankasandra, Bheemasandra, Belagehalli (Belagechalli), Ankasandra Kavalu (Ankasandra Kaval), Kanakere (Kankere), Bandrehalli (Bandarehalli), Yellenahalli (Ellenahalli), Otikere (Oteekere), Hosakere, Baraguru, Huchhanahalli (Huchchanahalli), Soralmavu, Rangenahalli, Ramaghatta, Tarikatte, Purada Katte (Puradakatte), Handanakere, Otakerethimmalapura (Otikere Timlapura), Lingadahalli, Yarekatte, Upalikannahalli, Harenahalli, Belagul (Belaguli), Devarahalli, Chaulukatte (Chowlakatte), Hallithimmalapura (Hallitimmalapura), Niruvagallu (Niruvagal), Gopalapura, Honnasshettyhalli (Honnasshettihalli), Sabbenahalli, Lakshmpipura (Lakshmpceepura), Bumanakatte (Bhumanakatte), Halumalledavarakavalu (H M Kaval), Baragihalli (Barageehalli), Chikka Ennigere (Chikka Ennegere), Avalagere, Byrapura Tanda, Byrapura (Bhairapura), Nandihalli, Kallahalli, Chikka Bidare, Seegebagi, Sangenahalli, Kodihalli, Dodda Bidare (Doddabidare), J.I.Timmalapura, Handhiganadu (Handiganadu), Sidlakatte, Koragere, Thoresooragondanahalli (Toresuragondanahalli), Salapura, Dinkannahalli, Pochakatte (Pochakatte), Barakanalu, Agrahara, Motihalli (Motehalli), Keresooragondanahalli (Keresuragondanahalli), Maratipalya, Taredahalli, Huliyur (TP), Bhattarahalli, Ballekatte, Yarehalli, Marahole (Maruhole), Gaudagere (Gowdagere), Karehalli, Yalanadu, Thammadihalli (Tammadihalli), Singapura, Kempannahalli, Boranakanave (Borakananive), Yegachihalli (Yagachehalli), Kurihatti, Ganadalu, Kenkere, Somanahalli, Guruvapura, Nulenuru, Dabbakunte (Dabbagunte), Melanahalli, Marenadu, Dasudi (Dasodi)		
S. No.2 Tehsil/Taluka: Tiptur	District: Tumakuru	State: Karnataka
Village Names		
Adhinaikanahalli (Adinayakanahalli), Kenchamaranahalli, Thimmarayanalli (Timmarayanahalli), Chaulihalli (Chowlihalli), Lakshmanapura, Bydarahalli, Halenahalli, Bairapura, Satterhamanahalli (Satteramanahalli), Gatakanakere (Ghatakinakere), Anivala, Hullahalli (Hulihalli), Halkurike Amanikere, Doddikatte, Dasanakatte, Rattenahalli, Halkurike Amruthmahal Kavalu (Halkurike Amrut Mahal Kaval), Halkurike, Mallidevihalli, Mayagondanahalli, Balavanerala (Baluvaneralu), Bommanahalli (Bommenahalli), Shingenahalli, Vaderahalli, Hosahalli, Gaudanakatte (Halagowdanakatte), Kodagihalli (Kodageehalli), Muddhenahalli (Muddenahalli), Rangapura (B Rangapura), Suragondanahalli, Rudrapura		
S. No.3 Tehsil/Taluka: Challakere	District: Chitradurga	State: Karnataka
Village Names		
Kyatannamale, Kalmarahalli, Hulikunte, Belagere Kavalu (Belegerekaval), Gorlattu, Belagere, Torebeeranahalli, Elagatte (Yalagatta), Chitragirinagara, Thimmanannaikanakote (T N Kote), Konigarahalli, Konigarahalli Kavalu (Konigarahallikaval), Gosikere, Gosikere Kavalu (Gosikerekaval), Choluru Kavalu (Chowlurukaval), Sooranahalli (Suranahalli), Chowluru, Purrehalli (Purallhalli), Bommanakunte, Timmanahalli (Timmannanahalli), Junjarkunte (Junjaragunte), Channamma Nagathihalli (Channammaganagathihalli), Chattekamba, Machchasamudra, Pagadalabande, Haravigondanahalli, Halgondanahalli, Nagagondanahalli, Jajuru, Jajuru Kavalu (Jajurukaval), Lakumgondanahalli (Lakumagondanahalli), Moduru Kavalu (Modurukaval), Moduru, Heggere, Jadekunte, Kaparahalli, Badavanahalli (Badavanahallibe), Sanikere Kavalu (Sanikere Kavalube), Badavanahalli Kavalu (Badavanahallikavaluchi), Sanikere, Chikkanahalli (Chikkenahalli), Nallurahalli, Bomberahalli, Mummadisagara, Vaderahalli, Gopanhalli, Devara Marikunte (Devaramarikunte), Jangamarahalli, Reddihalli, Siddapura, Kasturi Timmanahalli (Kasturitimmanahalli), Chenama Nagathihalli, Devaranahalli (Dyavaranahalli), Dodderi, Meerասabihalli, Vidappanakunte (Vidupanakunte), Bommasamudhra (Bommasamudra), Bharamasagara, Karikere (Karekere), Rangavvanahalli, Sampigetranda, Vishvesvarapura (Vishvesvarapura), Durgavara, Kalvehalli, Ullarthi Kavalu (Ullartikavalu), Kyatagondanahalli (Kyatagondanahalli), Doddavullarthi (Doddullarthi), Yadalagatta (Yadalaghatta), Gudehalli (Gudihalli), Thippagondanahalli (Thappagondanahalli), Donihalli Kavalu (Donnehallikavalu), Timmananahalli (Timmannanahalli), Chitranaikanahalli (Chitranyakanahalli), Valase, Channaganahalli, Kasavigondanahalli, Mailanahalli, Katam Devara Kote (Katandevarakote), Obalapura Kavalu (Obalapurakavalu), Obalapura, Basavagondanahalli, Renukapura, Putaparthi, Basapura, Bhoganahalli, Devareddihalli, Devarahalli, Gowrasamudradha Kavalu (Gowrasamudradkavalu), Mallasamudra, Bande Thimmalapura (Bandetimlapura)		
S. No.4 Tehsil/Taluka: Hiriyur	District: Chitradurga	State: Karnataka
Village Names		
Arsingundi (Arishinagundi), Sheshappanahalli, Mavinamadu, Uluvinahalu (Ulaval), Pillali, Kilaradahalli, Byaharmadu, Viravanagattihalli (Veeravvanagattihalli), Lakkenahalli, Handiganadu, Elladakere (Yalladakere), Layaradasanahalli, Obalapura, Dindavara, Madenahalli, Katanayakanahalli, Malagondanahalli, Rangapura, Iddalangenahalli, Gaudanahalli (Gowdanahalli), Baggenuadu (Baggenuadu Kaval), Challamadu, Ganjilagunte (Ganjilagunte), Vaddanahalli, Kasthuri Rangavvanahalli (K R Halli), Rayabommenahalli (Rayabommenahalli), Boranakunte, Adavala (Adivala), Ranganathapura, Upplegere (Upplagers), Samudradahalli, Elanadu (Yalanadu), Torsesalagenahalli (T Nagenahalli), Kudlahalli (Kodlahalli), Halamadenahalli (Hal Madenahalli), Haladyamenahalli, Hindasakatte, Uttare, Udevalli (Uduvalli), Paramenahalli, Katharikenahalli (Katrikenahalli), Hulagalakunte (Hulugalakunte), Somenahalli (Somerahalli), Lakkinalu (Lakkanal), Yaruchikkenahalli (Yaruchikkenahalli), Indiranagar, Doddagatte (Doddaghatta), Nandihalli, Pitlali, Patrihalli (Patrehalli), Lakkavvanahalli, Hiriyur (Rural), Koonikere (Kunikere), Aluru, Kasavanahalli, Hiriyur (CMC), Huchchavvanahalli, Sevalalnagar, Mayasandra, Bojapura (Bochapura), Babburu, Hosahatti, Masakallu (Maskal), Chinnayyanahatti, Myakaluralli (Myakalurahalli), Kundalaguru (Kundalagura), Hoovinahole (Huvinahole), Bedarahalli (Bydarahalli), Eshwaragere (Eeshvaragere), Devarakotte (Devarakotta), Chillahalli, Thore Obenahalli (T Obenahalli), Ambalagere, Kambattanahalli, Elegondanahalli (Yalagondanahalli), Abbinahole, Gollarahatti, Bidarekere (Bidara Kere), Upparahatti, Sangenahalli, Goolya (Gulya), Bhagavathikere (Bhagavatikere), Mangasavalli (Mungusavalli), Hosahalli, Gudanoorahalli (Gudurahalli), Sidliankote (Shidlryanakote), Rangenahalli, Sooguru (Suguru), Salahunase, Kanajanahalli, Yaradakatte, Metakurike (Metikurke), Gannayakanahalli, Hemadala, Balenahalli, Karevobenahalli (Kariyobenahalli), Giddobanahalli, Hartihikote (Hartikote), Kurudagirenahalli (Kurudugerenahalli), Mallappanahalli, Gulagondanahalli, Kalavibhagi (Kalavibagi), Eraballi (Yaraballi), Kandikere, Gollahalli, Maddanakunte		
S. No.5 Tehsil/Taluka: Hosadurga	District: Chitradurga	State: Karnataka
Village Names		
Heggere, Grantapura, Kudure Kanive Forest (K K Forest), Jaisuvarnapura (Jayasuvarnapura), Doddabyaladakere (Duddabyaladakere), Naganayakanakatte (Naganayakanakatte), Byadarahalli, Mugilodu, Gollarahalli, Chikkabyaladakere, Katihatti, Kittadalu (Kittadal), Kanchipura (Kancheepura), Kanabenahalli (Kanubenahalli), Chikkakarpoodadakatte (Chikkakarpuradakatte), Lakshmiddevarahalli (Lakshmeedevarahalli), Kasappanahalli		
S. No.6 Tehsil/Taluka: Bommanhal (Bommanahal)	District: Anantapur (Ananthapuramu)	State: Andhra Pradesh
Village Names		
Elanji, Singanahalli, Kolaganahalli, Sreedharaghattu (Sreedharaghatta), Govindawada, Bandur, Uddehal, Kalludevanahalli		
S. No.7 Tehsil/Taluka: Brahmasamudram	District: Anantapur (Ananthapuramu)	State: Andhra Pradesh
Village Names		
West Kodipalle, Pobbapallape, Eradikera, Bhyravanthippa, Brahmasamudram, Yerrakondapuram, Gundiganihalli, Vepalaparthi, Chelimenahalli, Bhairasamudram, Kannepalle		
S. No.8 Tehsil/Taluka: D. Hirehal (D. Hirchal)	District: Anantapur (Ananthapuramu)	State: Andhra Pradesh
Village Names		
Hulikal, Muradi, Dodagatta (Dodaghatta), Kadalur, Kudulur, Somalapuram, Nagalapuram, Pulakurthi		
S. No.9 Tehsil/Taluka: Gummagatta	District: Anantapur (Ananthapuramu)	State: Andhra Pradesh
Village Names		
Tallakera, Gummagatta, Rangasamudram, Kalugodu, Pulakunta, Galagala, Belodu, Gollapalle, Veerapuram, S.Hosahalli, Bhupasamudram		
S. No.10 Tehsil/Taluka: Kanekal	District: Anantapur (Ananthapuramu)	State: Andhra Pradesh
Village Names		
Hulikera, Kanekal, Yerragunta, Ganigera, Udegolam, Brahmasamudram, Bemikal		
S. No.11 Tehsil/Taluka: Rayadurg	District: Anantapur (Ananthapuramu)	State: Andhra Pradesh
Village Names		
Junjurampalle, Baginayakana Halli, Udegolam, Avuladatla, Rayadurg, Vadrakhonnur, Kontanapalli, D.Kondapuram, Bondankal (Bondanakal), Mallapuram, Gramadatla, Chadam		
II. LILO of one circuit of Talaguppa - Neelmangala 400 kV D/C line at CN'Halli		
S. No.1 Tehsil/Taluka: Chiknayakanahalli (Chiknayakanahalli)	District: Tumakuru	State: Karnataka
Village Names		
Shettykere (Shettikere), Madhihalli (Madihalli), Manchandra (Manchasandra), Thammadihalli, Benakanahalli, Hesarahalli, Dibbadahalli, Kuppuru, Kurubarahalli, Anekatte, Yarehalli, Aralikere (Aralekere), Pura, Muddhenahalli (Muddenahalli), Maraluhallada Kaval (M H Kaval), Gaurasagara (Gowrasagara), Gottigenahalli, Dasihalli (Dasechalli), Dagganahalli (Diggenahalli), Thagachikatte (Tagacheghatta), Madapura, Kamalapura, Bevinahalli, Matthighatta (Mattighatta), Chattasandra, Davanadahoshahalli (Davanada Hosahalli), Malligere, Mallenahalli, Upparahalli, Bangaragere, Kengalapura, Ankasandra, Bheemasandra, Belagehalli (Belagechalli), Ankasandra Kavalu (Ankasandra Kaval), Kanakere (Kankere), Bandrehalli (Bandarehalli), Yellenahalli (Ellenahalli), Otikere (Oteekere), Hosakere, Baraguru, Huchhanahalli (Huchchanahalli), Soralmavu, Rangenahalli, Ramaghatta, Tarikatte, Purada Katte (Puradakatte), Handanakere, Otakerethimmalapura (Otikere Timlapura), Lingadahalli, Yarekatte, Upalikannahalli, Harenahalli, Belagul (Belaguli), Devarahalli, Chaulukatte (Chowlakatte), Hallithimmalapura (Hallitimmalapura), Niruvagallu (Niruvagal), Gopalapura, Honnasshettyhalli (Honnasshettihalli), Sabbenahalli, Lakshmpipura (Lakshmpceepura), Bumanakatte (Bhumanakatte), Halumalledavarakavalu (H M Kaval), Baragihalli (Barageehalli), Chikka Ennigere (Chikka Ennegere), Avalagere, Byrapura Tanda, Byrapura (Bhairapura), Nandihalli, Kallahalli, Chikka Bidare, Seegebagi, Sangenahalli, Kodihalli, Dodda Bidare (Doddabidare), J.I.Timmalapura, Handhiganadu (Handiganadu), Sidlakatte, Koragere, Thoresooragondanahalli (Toresuragondanahalli), Salapura, Dinkannahalli, Pochakatte (Pochakatte), Barakanalu, Agrahara, Motihalli (Motehalli), Keresooragondanahalli (Keresuragondanahalli), Maratipalya, Taredahalli, Huliyur (TP), Bhattarahalli, Ballekatte, Yarehalli, Marahole (Maruhole), Gaudagere (Gowdagere), Karehalli, Yalanadu, Thammadihalli (Tammadihalli), Singapura, Kempannahalli, Boranakanave (Borakananive), Yegachihalli (Yagachehalli), Kurihatti, Ganadalu, Kenkere, Somanahalli, Guruvapura, Nulenuru, Dabbakunte (Dabbagunte), Melanahalli, Marenadu, Dasudi (Dasodi)		
S. No.2 Tehsil/Taluka: Tiptur	District: Tumakuru	State: Karnataka
Village Names		
Adhinaikanahalli (Adinayakanahalli), Kenchamaranahalli, Thimmarayanalli (Timmarayanahalli), Chaulihalli (Chowlihalli), Lakshmanapura, Bydarahalli, Halenahalli, Bairapura, Satterhamanahalli (Satteramanahalli), Gatakanakere (Ghatakinakere), Anivala, Hullahalli (Hulihalli), Halkurike Amanikere, Doddikatte, Dasanakatte, Rattenahalli, Halkurike Amruthmahal Kavalu (Halkurike Amrut Mahal Kaval), Halkurike, Mallidevihalli, Mayagondanahalli, Balavanerala (Baluvaneralu), Bommanahalli (Bommenahalli), Shingenahalli, Vaderahalli, Hosahalli, Gaudanakatte (Halagowdanakatte), Kodagihalli (Kodageehalli), Muddhenahalli (Muddenahalli), Rangapura (B Rangapura), Suragondanahalli, Rudrapura		
III. LILO at CN'Halli of already LILOed section of one circuit of Talaguppa - Neelmangala 400 kV line at Hassan		
S. No.1 Tehsil/Taluka: Chiknayakanahalli (Chiknayakanahalli)	District: Tumakuru	State: Karnataka
Village Names		
Shettykere (Shettikere), Madhihalli (Madihalli), Manchandra (Manchasandra), Thammadihalli, Benakanahalli, Hesarahalli, Dibbadahalli, Kuppuru, Kurubarahalli, Anekatte, Yarehalli, Aralikere (Aralekere), Pura, Muddhenahalli (Muddenahalli), Maraluhallada Kaval (M H Kaval), Gaurasagara (Gowrasagara), Gottigenahalli, Dasihalli (Dasechalli), Dagganahalli (Diggenahalli), Thagachikatte (Tagacheghatta), Madapura, Kamalapura, Bevinahalli, Matthighatta (Mattighatta), Chattasandra, Davanadahoshahalli (Davanada Hosahalli), Malligere, Mallenahalli, Upparahalli, Bangaragere, Kengalapura, Ankasandra, Bheemasandra, Belagehalli (Belagechalli), Ankasandra Kavalu (Ankasandra Kaval), Kanakere (Kankere), Bandrehalli (Bandarehalli), Yellenahalli (Ellenahalli), Otikere (Oteekere), Hosakere, Baraguru, Huchhanahalli (Huchchanahalli), Soralmavu, Rangenahalli, Ramaghatta, Tarikatte, Purada Katte (Puradakatte), Handanakere, Otakerethimmalapura (Otikere Timlapura), Lingadahalli, Yarekatte, Upalikannahalli, Harenahalli, Belagul (Belaguli), Devarahalli, Chaulukatte (Chowlakatte), Hallithimmalapura (Hallitimmalapura), Niruvagallu (Niruvagal), Gopalapura, Honnasshettyhalli (Honnasshettihalli), Sabbenahalli, Lakshmpipura (Lakshmpceepura), Bumanakatte (Bhumanakatte), Halumalledavarakavalu (H M Kaval), Baragihalli (Barageehalli), Chikka Ennigere (Chikka Ennegere), Avalagere, Byrapura Tanda, Byrapura (Bhairapura), Nandihalli, Kallahalli, Chikka Bidare, Seegebagi, Sangenahalli, Kodihalli, Dodda Bidare (Doddabidare), J.I.Timmalapura, Handhiganadu (Handiganadu), Sidlakatte, Koragere, Thoresooragondanahalli (Toresuragondanahalli), Salapura, Dinkannahalli, Pochakatte (Pochakatte), Barakanalu, Agrahara, Motihalli (Motehalli), Keresooragondanahalli (Keresuragondanahalli), Maratipalya, Taredahalli, Huliyur (TP), Bhattarahalli, Ballekatte, Yarehalli, Marahole (Maruhole), Gaudagere (Gowdagere), Karehalli, Yalanadu, Thammadihalli (Tammadihalli), Singapura, Kempannahalli, Boranakanave (Borakananive), Yegachihalli (Yagachehalli), Kurihatti, Ganadalu, Kenkere, Somanahalli, Guruvapura, Nulenuru, Dabbakunte (Dabbagunte), Melanahalli, Marenadu, Dasudi (Dasodi)		
S. No.2 Tehsil/Taluka: Tiptur	District: Tumakuru	State: Karnataka
Village Names		
Adhinaikanahalli (Adinayakanahalli), Kenchamaranahalli, Thimmarayanalli (Timmarayanahalli), Chaulihalli (Chowlihalli), Lakshmanapura, Bydarahalli, Halenahalli, Bairapura, Satterhamanahalli (Satteramanahalli), Gatakanakere (Ghatakinakere), Anivala, Hullahalli (Hulihalli), Halkurike Amanikere, Doddikatte, Dasanakatte, Rattenahalli, Halkurike Amruthmahal Kavalu (Halkurike Amrut Mahal Kaval), Halkurike, Mallidevihalli, Mayagondanahalli, Balavanerala (Baluvaneralu), Bommanahalli (Bommenahalli), Shingenahalli, Vaderahalli, Hosahalli, Gaudanakatte (Halagowdanakatte), Kodagihalli (Kodageehalli), Muddhenahalli (Muddenahalli), Rangapura (B Rangapura), Suragondanahalli, Rudrapura		

Copy of the route alignment is available in the office of the contact person. Notice is hereby given to the general public to make observation / representation on the proposed transmission system within two months from the date of publication of this notice to the office of the contact person details given below in writing. For further particulars and clarifications please contact:

Ananthapuram II Power Transmission Limited
Rajesh Kumar Singh (Director)
Address: Plot No. 137, Avtar Enclave, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110063
Email: head.powertrans@scegroup.co.in, Mob. No: +91 74284 87662, Ph.No: +91 11 4508 8679

Russian drone attack on Ukraine kills at least 18

SAMYA KULLAB/VASILISA STEPANENKO ■ Kyiv

Russia launched hundreds of drones and dozens of missiles against Kyiv and other Ukrainian cities overnight, killing at least 18 civilians and wounding more than 100 others, authorities said on Tuesday.

The damage trapped some people under the rubble of apartment buildings. Emergency crews digging through the wreckage pulled out the body of a three-year-old child and the bodies of a mother and her eight-year-old son in the central Ukrainian city of Dnipro, officials said. The attack stretched from night into day and the boom of explosions reverberated across cities.

Kyiv residents had been on edge for days after Russia warned that a massive aerial attack was coming and warned foreign diplomats to leave the Ukrainian capital. None appeared to heed the call.

“A large-scale attack and an explicit statement by Russia: If Ukraine is not protected from ballistic missiles and other missile strikes, those strikes will continue,” President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said in response to the attack, urging more support from the US and European countries.

Russian President Vladimir Putin has stepped up Moscow’s aerial campaign against Ukraine, with Russian forces recently launching a powerful hypersonic Oreshnik ballistic



missile for only the third time in the four-year war.

The Russian strategy seeks to take advantage of Ukraine’s shortage of US-made Patriot air defence missiles, with international stocks depleted by the Iran war. That has left civilians especially vulnerable to the Russian ballistic missile barrages, even as air defenses stop most of the attack drones. At least 64 people were wounded in the Capital, emergency services said.

Kyiv resident Iryna Salikova, 37, spent the night lying in a bath tub for protection with her 3-year-old daughter, as blasts reverberated across the city. “Our window was broken, a cobblestone flew into the children’s room,” Salikova said, though they weren’t hurt. “Thank God we’re alive. Today we’re alive,

today we’re lucky.”

Russia unleashed 73 missiles and 656 drones across Ukraine, according to the country’s air force, with the main targets including Kyiv, the central city of Dnipro, and the eastern cities of Poltava, Kharkiv and Zaporizhzhia. Ukrainian air defence forces destroyed or suppressed 40 missiles and 602 drones.

Putin is keen to generate some positive news from the conflict that began with Russia’s February 2022 invasion of its neighbour and hasn’t gone according to plan.

Western officials and analysts say Ukrainian drones are pinning down Russian troops on the front line, choking Russian supply lines in occupied regions of Ukraine and disrupting oil facilities deep inside Russia that

provide vital revenue for Moscow.

That has made the war, which Moscow refers to as a “special military operation,” more visible to Russians and increased pressure on Putin.

US-led peace efforts have fizzled out as the sides made no progress on key differences and after the Gulf and Middle East grabbed Washington’s attention. Zelenskyy accepted an unconditional ceasefire demanded by US President Donald Trump but Putin refused.

Russia’s Defence Ministry said in a statement that the military launched a “massive” strike with long-range precision weapons on military-industrial facilities in the Kyiv, Zaporizhzhia, Kharkiv, Dnipropetrovsk, Poltava, Khmelnytsk regions. (AP)

British Sikh MPs defend kirpan as UK Parliament debates murder

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Britain’s Sikh lawmakers on Tuesday defended the ceremonial knife, the *kirpan*, during a Parliament debate following the conviction of a British Sikh man who had presented his murder weapon as a religious item in court.

Vickrum Digwa, 23, was sentenced to life imprisonment on Monday after being found guilty of the murder of 18-year-old Henry Nowak, who was caught on police body-worn camera footage being handcuffed in his final moments over racism allegations.

Prime Minister Keir Starmer said he “felt sick” watching the “harrowing” footage but appealed against it being “whipped up” to create divisions within British society.

“There are clearly serious questions that need to be addressed, not least how accusations of racism informed the decision-making in this case,” Starmer said in a statement from 10 Downing Street.

As the incident from December last year in Southampton caused an uproar, UK Home Secretary Shabana Mahmood made a statement in the House of Commons to reiterate that the wider Sikh community must not be condemned for an individual’s “heinous crime”.

“There have been calls to limit the right of Sikhs to carry their ceremonial knife, the kirpan, one of the five holy items in their faith,” said Mahmood, referencing some far-right groups calling for a ban. The minister referenced the UK’s Offensive Weapons Act of 2019, which “clarified and strengthened existing legal protections in relation to long *kirpans*”.

“That included extending defences, so that *kirpans* can be lawfully possessed for religious reasons and used



in religious and ceremonial contexts. But let me be clear, carrying a knife for the purpose of religious observance is one thing, using it as so tragically occurred in this case is quite another. It is a vile act, a crime of the utmost severity, and it will be met with the severest punishment,” she said.

The Home Secretary went on to assert that the murder must not be allowed to turn communities against one another. “We do not believe in collective punishment in this country. Instead, we stand together against an act of pure evil. We condemn those who committed this heinous crime, not all those who share their faith or their ethnicity,” she said.

British Sikh members of Parliament were among those who made interventions during the heated Commons debate, with Labour MP Tanmanjeet Singh Dhosi condemning Reform UK and Restore Britain parties for “scapegoating and throwing under the bus an entire community based on the actions of one violent murderer”.

“What’s very galling is that the likes of

Reform, Restore and the far-right decided to politicise people’s pain, attacking the Sikh community for wearing the kirpan and wanting it banned, even though the kirpan was not used in this violent attack,” said Dhosi.

He referenced the history of thousands of Sikh soldiers bravely fighting alongside British soldiers in both World Wars while “wearing their turban and their kirpan”, as he called on Mahmood to reassure the community of its right to “freely and peacefully practise their faith”.

Fellow Labour MP Gurinder Singh Josan expressed his “shock and horror” over the senseless murder of Nowak and sought a meeting with Mahmood to discuss the fallout.

“There is simply no religious justification for these actions, a sentiment that is shared universally across the Sikh community. This case has raised many aspects of concern to my constituents, Sikh and non-Sikh, including issues of safety, knife crime and issues of freedom to practice one’s faith,” he said.

30 Indians held in US for illegal truck driving

YOSHITA SINGH ■ New York

About 30 individuals from India, found to be living in the US illegally and working as commercial truck drivers, have been arrested as part of a federal operation and will soon be deported.

The US Customs and Border Protection said in a statement on Monday that during the week of May 11-15, Border Patrol agents from Yuma Sector in Arizona arrested 52 individuals during ‘Operation Checkmate’ for being in the US illegally, including 36 who were found to be driving semi-trucks. Out of the 36 illegal semi-truck drivers arrested, 30 were from India, while the remaining six were from Mexico, El Salvador, and



Russia. They had commercial driver’s licences from States such as California, New York, Washington and Virginia, while some did not possess any form of driver’s licence.

Most possessed employment authorisation documents, which were obtained during the Joe Biden administration and were no longer

valid. All individuals were processed in accordance with federal law and will be deported.

Operation Checkmate is aimed at enhancing public safety through enforcement of immigration statutes to detect and arrest illegal persons operating commercial motor

vehicles in the country.

“Operation Checkmate reflects our commitment to safeguarding communities and roads from unlawfully present drivers who pose significant risks to public safety,” Acting Chief Patrol Agent of the US Border Patrol’s Yuma Sector Dustin Caudle said. Federal agents are on patrol every day to “ensure we stop these individuals and prevent more deadly crashes from occurring on the road across the United States.”

Under the administration of President Donald Trump, the Department of Transportation issued an order to stop unqualified foreign drivers from obtaining licenses to drive commercial trucks and buses. (PTI)

India and China eye stronger culture, tourism ties

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Beijing

India's Consul General in Shanghai, Pratik Mathur, held discussions with a Chinese cultural official on enhancing cultural exchanges and promoting tourism, as part of efforts to strengthen people-to-people ties in eastern China. Mathur interacted with a cross-section of Friends of India as part of ongoing efforts to further strengthen India's growing profile in eastern China and deepen cultural and diaspora linkages between the two coun-

tries, according to a press release issued by the Indian Consulate in Shanghai on Tuesday. During the engagements on Monday, Mathur met Zhang Jiaxing, Chief Executive Officer of the Guoyun Intangible Cultural Heritage Centre. The two sides discussed avenues for enhancing cultural exchanges, promoting mutual understanding, and encouraging greater tourist flows to India under the "Incredible India" campaign. They also underscored the importance of leveraging traditional cultural heritage



as a bridge for strengthening bilateral people-to-people ties, the release said. Mathur also inaugurated

THE TWO SIDES DISCUSSED AVENUES FOR ENHANCING CULTURAL EXCHANGES, PROMOTING MUTUAL UNDERSTANDING

a Yoga shivir (camp) at Dr Reddy's Laboratories in the Suzhou-Kunshan region as part of activities leading up to the annual International Day of Yoga (IDY), which will take place globally on June 21. The event, organised around the theme "Yoga for Healthy Ageing", drew

enthusiastic participation from members of the local community and highlighted the growing popularity of yoga and holistic wellness practices in eastern China. The envoy also announced the forthcoming "Magic Flute" concert series in Shanghai and Hangzhou. The performances will feature Indian flautist Rajat Prasanna and Mandy Chen, a noted Chinese tabla exponent. The concerts are expected to advance cultural collaboration further and bring Indian artistic traditions closer to Chinese audiences, the release said.

Jews are being targeted in Canada, says Carney

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Toronto

Canada is failing Jewish Canadians and the community is being brutally targeted by hate, Prime Minister Mark Carney said.

Carney said across Canada, antisemitism has surged to levels not seen in the post-World War II era. He noted that last year, over two-thirds of all religion-motivated hate crimes were directed at Jewish Canadians. Jews make up only 1 per cent of the population. "The horror and shame are global. Our actions must be local. They start with clearly admitting that Canada's civic compact is failing Jewish Canadians," Carney said at Holy Blossom Temple in Toronto.

Carney said antisemites in Canada have fired bullets at Jewish schools and thrown firebombs at synagogues and attacked community centres. He said they have targeted Jewish-owned businesses and driven Jewish students from common spaces on university campuses. Carney



said antisemitism plagues Europe, Australia and the United States. But he said the crisis of antisemitism in Canada is "specific, severe and demands a targeted response." There has been a sharp rise in antisemitic incidents globally since the Israel-Hamas war began on October 7, 2023. Noah Shack, the CEO of the Centre for Israel and Jewish Affairs, said before the speech that the Canadian government must do more to strengthen community security and combat hate. Carney said his Government has introduced legislation over the last year to combat antisemitism and other forms of hatred. (AP)

Trump taps Pulte as acting director of national intelligence after Gabbard

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

President Donald Trump has tapped Bill Pulte, head of the Federal Housing Finance Agency, to be the acting director of national intelligence — putting a real estate scion and fierce Trump loyalist in a key national security post as the US remains at war with Iran. Trump made the surprise announcement Tuesday on social media that Pulte would be replacing Tulsi Gabbard, the former Hawaii congresswoman who served as the director of national intelligence.

The Republican president cited Pulte's work at the FHFA and his role as chair of the mortgage giants Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac, saying that the 38 year-old "has deep experience managing the most sensitive matters in America, the safety and soundness of the Markets, and over 10 Trillion Dollars



at Fannie Mae/Freddie Mac, a substantial increase from where it was just 12 months ago."

Pulte's sudden elevation to a role coordinating sensitive national security matters is a sign of how Trump is putting a priority on loyalty over a traditional resume full of previous military and intelligence assignments. It's unclear what national security expertise Pulte has, but he has been a frequent guest

on Air Force One as Trump has traveled to Mar-a-Lago, his home and club in Palm Beach, Florida.

As the grandson of the founder of PulteGroup, one of the country's largest homebuilders, Pulte has cut a combative streak on social media and used his post at the FHFA to attack perceived opponents of the Trump administration.

His time overseeing mortgage finance has been linked with criminal refer-

als for mortgage fraud by public officials Trump sought to punish, including New York Attorney General Letitia James, a Democrat; Sen. Adam Schiff, D-Calif.; and Lisa Cook, a member of the Federal Reserve, who was nominated by a Democratic president, Joe Biden.

Pulte has famously gone after then-Federal Reserve Chair Jerome Powell for not cutting the central bank's benchmark interest rates as aggressively as the president wanted. He has also been linked to ideas such as the 50-year mortgage and efforts to lower mortgage rates through the purchase of home loan debt that have not paid off as promised.

Trump said Pulte will keep his other positions even as he fills in for Gabbard, who resigned last month after revealing her husband's cancer diagnosis. If formally nominated, Pulte would need to be confirmed by the Senate to hold the position full time.

EU strikes migration deal for more deportations, detention centres abroad

SAM MCNEIL
■ Brussels

The European Union (EU) has moved forward with a vast overhaul of its migration policy, aiming to ramp up deportations and ink controversial deals to build detention centres abroad, in what rights groups compare to the Trump administration's aggressive immigration policies.

"The new regulation will speed up the return process and increase returns of persons who have no legal right to stay in the EU," said Nicholas Ioannides,

deputy migration minister for Cyprus, which holds the rotating presidency of the 27-nation bloc.

The deal was struck between the EU's three main institutions — the European Commission, the European Council and the European Parliament — during a so-called "trilogue" on Monday evening. Critics compared the regulation to the immigration strategy of the Trump administration, which has struck a series of secretive agreements with nations around the world to deport thousands of people to countries that are not their own.



The United Kingdom also planned to deport migrants to Rwanda, but the plan was bogged down in legal red tape, and the new Government dropped the plan as soon as it came into

power. "The Regulation is going to create a draconian detention and deportation machine," said Silvia Carter, spokesperson for the Brussels-based Platform for International Cooperation

on Undocumented Migrants.

"Across the Atlantic, we see the violence and fear created by ICE's brutal immigration enforcement. Europe should be learning from the harms of that model, not building its own version of it." The provisional agreement will now head to the EU lawmakers and heads of state, where approval will likely be swift.

EU member nations will soon be able to set up bilateral deals with countries outside the bloc to build deportation centres. At least five EU nations - Germany, Austria, the Netherlands,

Denmark and Greece - are already in talks with third countries, mostly in Africa, to host "return hubs" on the model of Italy's detention deal with Albania.

The EU has continually tightened migration policies after right-wing parties took power in some countries in 2024. European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen, from the centre-right European People's Party coalition, has said that the new measures will prevent a repeat of the 2015 crisis caused by Syria's civil war, when about 1 million people arrived to seek asylum. (AP)

Kenyan President defends US Ebola quarantine centre



A protester raises a Kenyan flag near a burning barricade during a demonstration against a proposed Ebola quarantine center to be established by the United States at Laikipia Air Base in Nanyuki in Kenya on Monday. AP

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Nairobi

Kenya's president on Monday defended the establishment of an Ebola quarantine facility by the US, a move that led to protests despite a court order blocking the plan.

President William Ruto on Monday night said the US had a long-standing partnership with Kenya on health matters and that the quarantine facility at Laikipia Air Base was one of 24 facilities that had been established in the event of an Ebola outbreak in the country. Some Kenyans have opposed the Laikipia facility after the US last week said no American Ebola patient would be allowed to return home and that patients would instead be quarantined at the facility in Kenya. The US intends to commit \$13

million to the partnership with Kenya.

The high court on Tuesday extended orders issued on Friday suspending the construction of the facility and the arrival of foreign patients. The case had been filed by the Law Society of Kenya and a constitutional watchdog, Katiba Institute, which cited Kenya's fragile health system as unable to handle foreign patients. Speaking for the first time on the matter, Ruto said he agreed to the establishment of the facility based on existing bilateral relations. "When President Trump asked the Government of Kenya to support them by having a centre at Laikipia Air Base, I gave the OK because it was an agreement and a partnership with friends who have worked with Kenya for 30-40 years," he said.

Mette Frederiksen to start third term as Denmark's PM

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Copenhagen

Social Democrat Mette Frederiksen is set to begin a third term as Denmark's prime minister, leading a centre-left coalition of four parties after two months of negotiations.

Besides Frederiksen's own party, the new Government will include the centrist Moderate party of outgoing Foreign Minister Lars Løkke Rasmussen, the Green Left (SF), and the Danish Social Liberal Party, the Danish Royal House said in a statement on Monday. It will be a government working for "the



people of Denmark, for the generations to come and for the animals," Frederiksen said Monday night.

Animal welfare was one of several issues that were debated during the campaign. Frederiksen had called an early election in February, apparently hoping her party would receive a boost from her straight-talking image in the stand-off with US President Donald Trump over the future of the kingdom's semiautonomous territory of Greenland.

Neither left-leaning nor right-leaning blocs won a majority in Parliament after the March vote. Denmark's

system of proportional representation typically produces coalition Governments that are traditionally made up of several parties from either the left or the right.

Frederiksen's ruling coalition was created after two failed attempts to form a Government, one by Frederiksen and another by outgoing Defence Minister Troels Lund Poulsen, who had sought to form a centre-right Government.

The new Government's priorities will be presented on Tuesday, with the names of new ministers announced on Wednesday. The 48-year-old prime

minister has led the European Union and NATO member country since mid-2019. This time around, her party won 38 seats in the 179-seat single-chamber parliament, which was 12 fewer than in the 2022 elections. Frederiksen is known for strong support of Ukraine in its defence against Russia's invasion and for a restrictive approach to migration.

In her second term, her support waned as the cost of living rose. But she enjoyed a bump in popularity as the Government navigated the crisis over Trump's designs on Greenland.

Pakistan sees 27% increase in terror attacks in May: Report

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Militancy-driven violence spiked 27 per cent in Pakistan last month compared to the preceding month, showing the deep prevalence of terrorism-linked threats to the country, according to a think tank report. Militant and terror groups regained momentum during May after a brief period of relative decline, said a monthly security assessment released on Monday by the Pakistan Institute for Conflict and Security Studies (PICSS).

According to the report, the country witnessed 128

terrorist attacks during May, compared to 101 attacks in April, representing a 27 per cent increase. In May, 71 civilians, 68 security personnel and six members of peace committees were killed, while 147 civilians, 35 security personnel and three peace committee members were injured.

The report showed that compared to April, civilian fatalities increased from 37 to 71, representing a 92 per cent rise, while security personnel fatalities surged from 28 to 68, marking a 143 per cent increase. The report also showed a sharp increase in suicide attacks as the country witnessed six suicide attacks



during May, including four vehicle-borne suicide bombings. These attacks alone resulted in the deaths of 34 security personnel and nine civilians. In comparison, only one suicide attack was recorded

in each of March and April, indicating a significant escalation in the use of suicide bombings by terrorist groups. Balochistan emerged as the most affected province during the month. The province

Rajapaksa allowed to testify online on forced disappearances



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Sri Lanka's former president Gotabaya Rajapaksa was on Tuesday allowed to testify online in a long-standing case about the disappearance of two rights activists in 2011.

Rajapaksa was the chief bureaucrat in the Ministry of Defence under the presidency of his elder brother, Mahinda Rajapaksa, when the disappearances of human rights activists Lalith Kumar Weeraraju and Kugan Muruganandan were reported. Before their disappearance, Weeraraju and Muruganandan were reportedly planning to hold a press conference in Colombo on a protest to highlight human rights violations against Tamil civilians since the end of a military conflict in the island nation in 2009. The Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) waged a

military campaign for a separate Tamil homeland in the northern and eastern provinces for nearly 30 years before its collapse.

On Tuesday, Rajapaksa was granted permission to testify online without physically presenting himself at the magistrate's court in Tamil-dominated Jaffna.

Earlier, during his presidential term from 2019-2022, Rajapaksa appealed to the Court of Appeal that he felt unsafe travelling to make the court appearance in Jaffna, the Northern Province's capital. The court upheld his plea.

At the time of the right activists' disappearance, Rajapaksa was accused of overseeing abduction squads that whisked away rebel suspects, critical journalists, and activists, many of them never to be seen again. He previously denied any wrongdoing.

Pakistan forces kill 17 militants in Balochistan



SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Pakistani security forces have killed at least 17 militants in a series of operations in the restive Balochistan province in reaction to the deadly train attack of last week, the army said on Tuesday.

At least 14 people were killed in a bomb attack by terrorists at a shuttle train in the military areas of the provincial capital Quetta on May 24. The banned Baloch Liberation Army (BLA) claimed responsibility for the blast.

According to a statement issued by the army, after the train incident, the security forces conducted a series of

intelligence-based operations in Mastung, Nushki, Zehri, Khuzdar and Ketch districts of Balochistan. It said that during these operations, the troops effectively engaged multiple terrorist locations.

Following intense and fierce exchanges of fire, 17 terrorists belonging to the BLA "have been sent to hell, giving a significant blow to the terrorist networks operating in these areas," it stated.

It added that weapons, ammunition and a large cache of explosives and prepared improvised explosive devices have also been recovered from the terrorists. (PTI)

REPORT
● The country witnessed 128 terrorist attacks during May, compared to 101 attacks in April, representing a 27 per cent increase
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● The report showed that compared to April, civilian fatalities increased from 37 to 71, representing a 92 per cent rise, while security personnel fatalities surged from 28 to 68, marking a 143 per cent increase

recorded 71 terrorist attacks, compared with 34 in April, representing a 109 per cent increase. The deteriorating security situation was further reflected in a surge in kidnappings. Of the 54 abductions

reported nationwide during May, 52 occurred in Balochistan alone. Despite the increase in terrorist activity, security forces intensified counterterrorism operations across the country. (PTI)

PROSPECT
Govt appoints V Packirisamy as Director PFC

The Government has appointed V Packirisamy as Director (Commercial) at Power Finance Corporation Limited (PFC), effective June 2, a statement said on Tuesday. He was serving as Executive Director, Entity Appraisal & IT, PFC, the company said in an exchange filing. Packirisamy brings over three decades of extensive experience in the power sector and infrastructure finance. He holds a BE (Mechanical) and an MTech (Management and Systems) from IIT Delhi. The official began his professional career in 1989 and joined PFC in 1997. Over the years, he played a pivotal role in expanding the organisation's operations and strengthening its appraisal and risk management frameworks, significantly contributing to the growth of PFC's loan portfolio. He has been instrumental in several key institutional initiatives, including the development of methodologies for categorising state generation and transmission utilities, formulation of the Integrated Rating Framework for Power Distribution Companies approved by the Ministry of Power, and drafting appraisal policies for private sector entities. In addition, he serves as a nominee director on the Board of Telangana North Discom and is the President of the Power Foundation of India.



Assam CM meets new NITI Aayog VC, seeks stronger reforms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Tuesday congratulated Dr Ashok Lahiri on his recent appointment as the Vice Chairman of NITI Aayog and expressed the state's commitment to strengthening its partnership with the national policy think tank. Sharing details of his meeting with Dr Lahiri in the national capital, Sarma said the newly appointed Vice Chairman 'brings with him extensive experience in public policy and finance,' highlighting the expertise he is expected to bring to NITI Aayog's policymaking and reform agenda. The Chief Minister noted that the Assam Government is keen to deepen its engagement with NITI Aayog in implementing reforms and developmental policies. 'The



Assam Govt aims to deepen its partnership with NITI Aayog in implementing reforms and policies that will improve the Ease of Living of our people," Sarma said in a post on X after the meeting. The interaction comes as Assam continues to pursue governance reforms, infra-

structure development and welfare initiatives with support from central institutions. Officials believe closer collaboration with NITI Aayog will help accelerate policy implementation and enhance outcomes across key sectors. Dr Lahiri, a distinguished economist and public policy

expert, has held several important positions in government and academia. His appointment as Vice Chairman of NITI Aayog is expected to bolster the institution's role in shaping India's development priorities and supporting states in achieving sustainable and inclusive growth.

Delhi CM meets German delegation; discuss key sectors



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta met a German delegation and discussed opportunities of cooperation in infrastructure, digital governance, mobility, water management, education sectors, with it at Delhi Secretariat, the CMO said on Tuesday. The chief minister had a productive interaction with Mario Voigt, minister-president of German state of Thuringia, and the accompanying delegation, it said in a post on X. The two sides discussed opportu-

nities to strengthen cooperation in the fields of smart urban development and sustainable infrastructure, digital governance and innovation, skill development, mobility, water management and environmental technologies, education and workforce development, it said. The India-Germany partnership continues to grow strong across diverse sectors, under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Delhi is proud to contribute to this shared journey of innovation, sustainability and human development, it added.

Sashastra Seema Bal takes initiative towards welfare of force personnel and bright future of their children

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Continuing its commitment towards the welfare of Force personnel and their families, the Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB) on Tuesday signed a significant Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the prestigious educational institution Pawan Ganga Educational Society (PGES), New Delhi. The objective of this agreement is to provide quality and affordable educational opportunities to the children of Force personnel, particularly those of martyrs and serving personnel, enabling them to shape a brighter and more promising future through better academic exposure. On this occasion, Sanjay Singhal, Director General, Sashastra Seema Bal, stated that the Force has always accorded the highest priority to the welfare of its personnel and their families. He emphasized that SSB personnel serve the nation under challenging and demanding conditions along the borders, and therefore



ensuring quality education and a secure future for their children is a moral responsibility of the Force. He described the agreement as a significant achievement for SSB families and expressed confidence that it would provide the wards of personnel with access to quality education, modern resources, and enhanced career opportunities. Senior officers and personnel from Force Headquarters attended the programme, while officers and personnel from various frontier and field formations joined virtually. Representing Pawan Ganga Educational Society, Colonel Ashok Kaul, Director,

PGES, Swati Joshi, Principal, GIS, and other distinguished representatives of the institution participated in the event and described the partnership as a positive initiative in the interest of society. Under the agreement, 10 completely free seats will be provided at GIS School for wards of SSB martyrs, with only mess charges being applicable. In addition, 250 eligible wards of SSB personnel will receive up to 60 per cent fee concession. Furthermore, 40 per cent fee concession will be provided on 50 seats under the Public Outreach Programme. Significant benefits have also

been ensured in the field of higher education, including 05 full tuition waiver seats at GITAM for the wards of SSB martyrs and 20 per cent tuition fee concession for 100 wards of SSB personnel. The agreement extends beyond fee concessions and focuses on the holistic development of students by facilitating access to skill development programmes, innovation and research ecosystems, internships, entrepreneurship support, career counseling and placement assistance. These initiatives will help equip the children of SSB families with the knowledge, skills and opportunities required to compete effectively at national and global levels. On the occasion, Rekha Lohani, Additional Director General, Ratn Sanjay, Inspector General (Int), Ganesh Kumar, Inspector General (Pers), Somit Joshi, Inspector General (Admn.) along with other senior officers of the Force and distinguished representatives of the educational institution, were also present.

Mission 'Senehjori' launched to boost Assam's Muga Silk sector; ₹411-crore project to benefit 2.5 lakh stakeholders

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a major initiative aimed at transforming Assam's iconic Muga Silk industry, Union Minister for Development of North Eastern Region (DoNER) Jyotiraditya Scindia on Tuesday virtually launched Mission Muga Silk 'Senehjori', a '411-crore project designed to empower more than 2.5 lakh weavers, rearers and entrepreneurs associated with Muga silk production in Assam. The launch event held at Sanchar Bhawan in the national capital, was attended by Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, Minister of State for Textiles Pabitra Margherita and Minister of State for DoNER Sukanta Majumdar, among others. Describing the initiative as a transformative step for Assam's famed 'golden thread', Scindia said the mission would enhance value addition, improve production and quality, economically empower stakeholders and position Muga silk competitively in global markets. "This initiative is to take Muga Silk from farm gate to foreign shore," Scindia said while launching the ambitious three-year project, which will be implemented from 2026 to 2028. Highlighting the Centre's vision for the Northeast, Scindia said the eight



states of the region, collectively known as 'Ashtalakshmi', have been identified based on their unique strengths and potential. While Nagaland has been identified for coffee, Tripura for pineapple, Sikkim for organic farming, Arunachal Pradesh for kiwi, Mizoram for organic ginger and Manipur for polo, Assam has been recognised for its world-renowned Muga Silk. The Union Minister noted that the mission involves the collaboration of 11 stakeholders, including the Ministry of DoNER, Government of Assam, Ministry of Textiles, Ministry of Cooperation, APEDA, ICAR, DRDO and representatives of the weaving and rearing communities. As part of the project, five modern reeling units will be established at Jorhat, Sivasagar, Suakuchi, Majuli and Lakhimpur. A dedicated Muga silk unit will also be set up at Dhemaji to strengthen processing and value-addition capabilities. Speaking on the occasion, Assam

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said the mission would provide a major boost to Muga Silk, which remains a symbol of Assam's cultural heritage and pride. He expressed confidence that the initiative, the first of its kind to promote the golden thread, launched under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia, would unlock the vast economic potential of the sector that has remained largely untapped. Sarma also pointed out that the Geographical Indication (GI) tag accorded to Muga Silk has given the product a distinct identity and the new mission would significantly enhance both the quality and quantity of production. Minister of State for Textiles Pabitra Margherita and Minister of State for DoNER Sukanta Majumdar also addressed the gathering. The programme connected virtually with weavers, rearers and stakeholders from various districts of Assam, along with representatives from different ministries and departments. Senior officials present included DoNER Secretary Sanjay Jaju, Additional Chief Secretary to the Assam Chief Minister Dr KK Dwivedi, Resident Commissioner of Assam Bhawan Kavitha Padmanabhan and other government representatives. Assam Chief Secretary Dr Ravi Kota and senior state officials joined the event virtually.

DAILY SUDOKU

	4					9	7	
			8	9	7			3
		9	3					2
6			2		8			5
	7		4					
4					6	3		
1			5	8	9			
	8	6					2	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

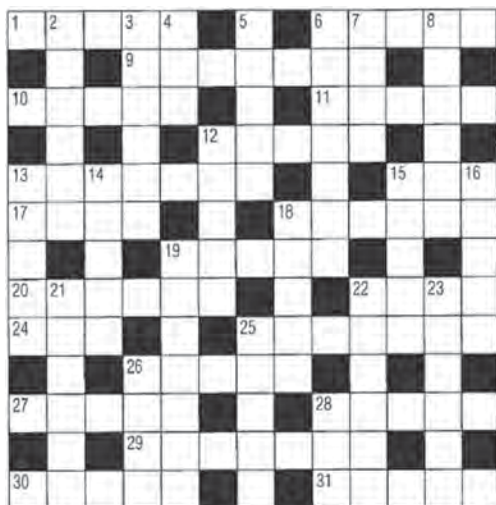
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (2.6.26)

2	8	9	6	1	4	7	3	5
1	7	4	2	3	5	8	9	6
5	3	6	9	7	8	2	1	4
8	5	7	4	6	1	3	2	9
6	4	2	8	9	3	5	7	1
9	1	3	7	5	2	4	6	8
3	9	1	5	8	7	6	4	2
4	6	5	3	2	9	1	8	7
7	2	8	1	4	6	9	5	3

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
WEDNESDAY | JUNE 3, 2026



ACROSS

- 1 A big hit by accident? (5)
- 6 Do a stretch up the river? (5)
- 9 You'd need to go a long way to put anything across him! (4,3)
- 10 Modern motorway junction, you'll agree (5)
- 11 Possibly came out of the cold to a holy city (5)
- 12 Appeal quietly for the best part (5)
- 13 Many a blemish on an article is cosmetic! (7)
- 15 House key, often Dutch (3)
- 17 Roguish as some anarchists (4)

DOWN

- 2 Medium large portions of fruit (6)
- 3 If you want a change, throw it! (6)
- 4 A Whitehall success? (3)
- 5 Ladle out for a woman (5)
- 6 Cameron's new love (7)
- 7 Regarded as hackneyed, ultimately? (4)
- 8 Foolish flier? (6)
- 12 Supporters in favour of something extra (5)
- 13 German goods include fruit (5)
- 14 Fight maybe broken off (5)
- 15 Get away with an injured foot? (3,2)

- 18 Wherein to play cards with the boys? (6)
- 19 Variety in life? (5)
- 20 Grand people, goddesses in fact (6)
- 22 Trot out of sight, we hear (4)
- 24 One initially entitled to a bus pass? (3)
- 25 Garment for the labourer? (7)
- 26 To plagiarise is in bad taste, always (5)
- 27 So hot, possibly, as to kill! (5)
- 28 A brushed coat (5)
- 29 Claimed to be legal, perhaps, by the Editor (7)
- 30 Be inclined to upset the Poles (5)
- 31 Wait for dad to get employment (5)

- 16 Swimmer, always about fifty (5)
- 18 Look displeased with a learner on a vessel (5)
- 19 One has to settle outside the city (7)
- 21 I leave Charlie to go swimming with her! (6)
- 22 Country name on a tin (6)
- 23 Rising, set out for a pub game (6)
- 25 Kept being sad about a historic day (5)
- 26 Sort of opera with a certain fragrance? (4)
- 28 Either way, it's enlivening! (3)

NCDFI, Assam Rifles sign MoA to bolster milk supply via cooperatives

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

National Cooperative Dairy Federation of India Ltd. (NCDFI) and Assam Rifles signed a Memorandum of Agreement (MoA) in New Delhi to further strengthen cooperation for the supply of milk and milk products through the dairy cooperative network. The MoA was exchanged by Brig Sachinder Tiwari, SM, Brig (Adm), Directorate General Assam Rifles and Srinivas Sajja, MD, NCDFI, in the august presence of Lt Gen Vikas Lakhera, AVSM, SM, Director General, Assam Rifles, and Dr Meenesh Shah, Chairman, NCDFI & NDDB. The occasion marked an important milestone in expanding the role of dairy cooperatives in meeting the requirements of Assam Rifles.

During the previous year, NCDFI facilitated contracts with Assam Rifles



for the supply of UHT milk by Amul (Gujarat) and Nandini (Karnataka), Whole Milk Powder by Warana Milk Union (Maharashtra), and fresh milk by Manipur, Mizoram and Tripura Milk Unions. Accordingly, in addition to the previous year's contracts, Malt Based Food and Cheese are now being supplied by Amul, while fresh milk and butter are being supplied by WAMUL (Assam), Dimapur (Nagaland), Bhagirathi (West Bengal) and Alwar (Rajasthan) Milk Unions. The MoA reflects the shared commitment of NCDFI and Assam Rifles

towards ensuring a dependable supply of quality milk and milk products to Assam Rifles units, while also creating meaningful market opportunities for dairy cooperatives and their farmer members, with particular emphasis on strengthening dairy development and farmer empowerment in the North Eastern region. Speaking on occasion, Lt Gen Vikas Lakhera, AVSM, SM, appreciated the consistent efforts of NCDFI and the participating dairy cooperatives in meeting the requirements of Assam Rifles. Dr Meenesh Shah said that the association with Assam Rifles is a matter of pride for dairy cooperative sector. He stated that NCDFI has had the privilege of facilitating supplies of milk and milk products to Indian Army and ITBP for last four decades, and the partnership with Assam Rifles further strengthens this trusted association with national institutions.

Mother Dairy unveils naturally degradable milk pouch

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Mother Dairy on Tuesday unveiled India's first naturally degradable milk pouch in soil that would leave no trace of plastics in environment. The company will use this new degradable milk pouch in its cow milk variant sold across Delhi-NCR from June 5 which marks World Environment Day. Mother Dairy is a wholly-owned subsidiary of National Dairy Development Board (NDDB). "The newly introduced packaging is designed to naturally degrade in soil within a few years rather than centuries, and importantly, this transition is being undertaken without any impact on consumer milk prices," Meenesh Shah, Chairman of NDDB, said. Mother Dairy is committed to safeguarding the planet, he said. Mother Dairy said its new milk pouch uses a first-of-



develop a naturally degradable milk pouch that leaves no trace of plastics in the environment." While these milk pouches will continue to remain recyclable, he said the key differentiator lies in their ability to degrade into natural elements, thereby helping address the challenge of fugitive plastic. Mother Dairy, which was commissioned in 1974, manufactures, markets & sells milk and milk products including cultured products, ice creams, paneer, ghee, etc. under the 'Mother Dairy' brand. The company also has a diversified portfolio with products in edible oils under the 'Dhara' brand and fresh fruits & vegetables, frozen vegetables & snacks, pulps & concentrates, etc. under the 'Safal' brand. On the issue of price rise on its milks, Shah asserted that the milk supply situation and procurement of milk from farmers in the country are comfortable now. On con-

cerns related to supply of fodder in view of IMD's forecast of below normal monsoon, Shah said there should not be any problem in the total availability of fodder. He said there could be problem in some states, but that could be compensated by other parts of the country. Shah said the country's milk production is expected to rise 4-6 per cent this fiscal year from around 250 million tonnes in the previous year. The NDDB Chairman noted that growth in milk production annually is in line with rising consumption and asserted that there would not be any issue in meeting this growing demand for dairy products over the next 10-15 years. Shah said government has taken various measures to boost milk production through improvement of animal health and their productivity. More dairy cooperative societies are being formed across the country.

BRIEFLY

Dutch legend joins Indian team for specialised dragflicking camp



Legendary Dutch dragflicker Taeke Taekema has joined the senior Indian women's hockey team for a specialised training camp focused on dragflicking and penalty-corner execution during the ongoing tour of Australia and New Zealand. Taekema has been brought in to further sharpen the skills of dragflickers as the Indian team prepares for the FIH Nations Cup, scheduled to take place in New Zealand from June 15 to 21, under its chief coach Sjoerd Marijne. Indian dragflickers Deepika, Lalthantluangi and Annu are participating in the focused training sessions, aimed at sharpening India's penalty-corner conversions and overall attacking efficiency ahead of a crucial international season. Taekema is regarded as one of the finest dragflickers world hockey has seen. A former Netherlands international, Taekema was known for his powerful penalty-corner conversions and represented the Dutch national team in multiple major international tournaments, including the Olympic Games and FIH Hockey World Cups. He has over 200 appearances and 221 international career goals to his name. As part of the preparations for the Nations Cup in Auckland, India played a friendly series of four matches against Australia at the Perth Hockey Stadium from May 26 to 30. Both the teams won two matches each, ending the series in a 2-2 draw. (PTI)

English conditions no longer alien: Anjum Chopra



The English conditions are no longer "alien" for the Indian women's cricket team, who will start as favourites at the upcoming T20 World Cup, says former captain Anjum Chopra. The 'Women in Blue' begin their T20 World Cup campaign against arch-rivals Pakistan in Birmingham on June 14. "England conditions are not alien. Few of them or most of them have already played there, at least the core of this Indian team." For Nandini (Sharma), yes, she is playing there. But in a very small career of Shree Charani, this is her second tour to England in less than 12 months," Chopra told PTI in an exclusive interaction. "For me, India will always remain one of the favourite sides. Obviously, I want them there. Not only in the top four. I want them in the top two and then the top team," she added. One of the biggest positives for India in the lead-up to the World Cup has been the return of wicketkeeper-batter Yastika Bhatia from a lengthy injury layoff. The left-hander made an immediate impact on her comeback, scoring a fluent 54 off 40 balls in the opening T20I against England, a match in which skipper Harmanpreet Kaur was rested. (PTI)

Southampton to stick by manager Eckert after Spygate controversy

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Southampton

Southampton manager Tonda Eckert will keep his job despite helping to orchestrate the Spygate controversy that cost the club a chance of promotion to the Premier League, owner Dragan Solak said on Tuesday.

Southampton was expelled from the second-tier Championship playoffs last month after admitting to repeatedly spying on opponents' training sessions and also given a four-point deduction for next season.

In its written reasons published on Monday, an arbitra-



tion panel laid bare the influence of Eckert in the scandal, saying it was "a contrived and determined plan from top down to gain a competitive

Aryna Sabalenka ends Naomi's show in Paris

ANDREW DAMPF/
JEROME PUGMIRE ■ Paris

Naomi Osaka may have had the edge in the fashion contest. In the tennis department, though, top-ranked Aryna Sabalenka was the winner. Sabalenka beat Osaka 7-5, 6-3 on Monday to reach the French Open quarterfinals and move one step closer to finally winning the clay-court Grand Slam, where she lost last year's final to Coco Gauff.

It was the first women's night match at Roland Garros in three years and Osaka entered the court wearing a golden bomber jacket over her gold sequin playing dress, trailing a tiered train with

puffs of tulle. Sabalenka wore more standard tennis attire: A slightly sheer black flared tennis dress with a red under-layer; plus diamond necklaces. In the matchup of four-time Grand Slam champions, Sabalenka improved to 3-1 in her career against Osaka, who was playing in the fourth round at Roland Garros for the first time.

Sabalenka overpowered Osaka from the baseline, and produced a huge forehand return winner on her first match point that Osaka barely got her racket on. Tournament organizers had been criticized for not scheduling more women's matches at night, with Roland Garros officials responding that



women's best-of-three set matches don't occupy enough time for TV broadcasters. The men play best-of-five set matches.

Sabalenka won in 1 hour, 27 minutes. "The atmosphere and the attention that this match brought (is) going to show them that probably for

Osorio, Nelson score in Canada's win over Uzbekistan

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Edmonton (Alberta)

Jonathan Osorio, making his 90th appearance with the Canadian national team, scored a second-half goal and Canada went on to defeat Uzbekistan 2-0 in a World Cup tune-up on Monday night.

Osorio, who came into the match to start the second half, scored his first goal for Canada since 2023 in the 58th minute with a blast that got past Uzbekistan goalkeeper Abduvohid Nematov. It was Osorio's 10th international goal.

Jayden Nelson, who also came off the bench, added Canada's second goal in stoppage time. Tani Oluwaseyi



assisted both goals. Canadian defender Moise Bombito was subbed out of the match in the 31st minute and later limped to the locker room with his lower left leg wrapped in ice.

Bombito had not played for the national team since

fracturing his left tibia in a 2-2 draw with Monaco in October.

Canada had already lost midfielder Marcelo Flores, who tore a ligament in his right knee on Saturday while playing for UANL Tigres in the CONCACAF Champions Cup

final. Nelson, who was not named to Canada's World Cup squad, may have earned Flores' roster spot with his performance against Uzbekistan. Goalkeeper Maxime Crepeau played the first half and was replaced by Dayne St. Clair in the second in a pre-planned change for Canada. Coach Jesse Marsch named his World Cup squad on Friday.

Alphonso Davies was included on the team despite a hamstring injury that may keep him out of the opener. The Edmonton native looked on, but was not available for Monday's match. Canada opens the World Cup on June 12 in Toronto against Bosnia and Herzegovina in Group B.

Injured Canada captain Alphonso rejoins team

ANNE M PETERSONAP
■ Toronto

Alphonso Davies has joined the Canadian national team as it prepares for the World Cup, although he's not quite ready to play.

The left back injured a hamstring last month while playing for Bayern Munich in 1-1 draw with Paris Saint-Germain that knocked the German club out the Champions League semifinals. On Monday, Davies was on the sideline when Canada beat Uzbekistan 2-0 in a rainy World Cup tuneup in his hometown of Edmonton, Alberta. The Canadian captain ran laps on the field before the game.

"It feels nice to get back on the pitch and do some running. I'm happy to be



home, I'm happy to be with the boys and support them, whether it's just on or off the pitch," said Davies, who joined the squad on Sunday.

Davies, who has 15 goals in 58 games for Canada, was named Friday to its 26-player squad for the World Cup. He would not speculate about when he might be able to

play. Canada opens the World Cup on June 12 in Toronto against Bosnia and Herzegovina.

"We just have to see how everything goes over the next couple days," Davies said. "I'll just continue my rehab, my progression, and see how I'm feeling, day by day, step by step." Davies has

not played for Canada since March 2025, when he tore an ACL in the CONCACAF Nations League finals.

"It was tough. I mean, the last year was obviously an up-and-down moment for me, with the ACL that happened, with the low muscle injuries here and there, but at the end of the day I think I just have to keep my head down, keep working, can't let that affect me," he said. "Obviously, it was tough mentally and physically, but I'm feeling good now, and hoping to recover as quickly as possible."

Canada coach Jesse Marsch said Davies should not feel pressured to return too soon. "What we don't want to do is put him in a situation to suffer again and to be vulnerable again. (AP)

McEnroe anxious to wrap up French Open duties



ANDREW DAMPF
■ Paris

John McEnroe was 14 when the New York Knicks last won the NBA title. Now 67, the former top-ranked tennis player and basketball fan is anxious to get back home from his TV commentating duties at the French Open in time to attend the Knicks' first home game of the NBA Finals.

"You can't ask for anything better. I've been waiting only 53 years," McEnroe said. "So, time has come. It's going to be awesome because (Victor) Wembanyama is out of this world. Can't ask for a better matchup. It is like a dream matchup, it's like getting your best guys to do their thing."

The French Open ends Sunday. Game 3 of the NBA Finals is in New York the next day.

"Hopefully I'll be there," McEnroe said in Paris on Monday. A French reporter asked McEnroe if he's afraid of Wembanyama - the Frenchman who leads the

last eight after defeating Anastasia Potapova 6-4, 2-6, 7-6 (10-7).

"Thinking two weeks ago that I will be here, I wouldn't believe it," Kalinskaya said. "I would probably laugh with my team." Many top women's players were already eliminated, including aiff, four-time winner Iga Swiatek and No. 2-ranked Elena Rybakina.

Sinner's out but Italians move on: Despite top-ranked Jannik Sinner losing in second round, Italian fans will have at least two men in quarterfinals. Tenth-seeded Flavio Cobolli advanced to his second Grand Slam quarterfinal - and his first here - after beating American Zachary Svajda 6-2, 6-3, 6-7 (3), 7-6 (5). (AP)

Serena Williams returns back to professional tennis at 44

ANDREW DAMPF
■ Paris

Serena Williams is coming back to professional tennis at the age of 44, returning to the sport she dominated for two decades before famously "evolving" away from the daily grind of competition.

First up for the 23-time Grand Slam singles champion is the doubles tournament at Queen's Club. But Wimbledon and the U.S. Open could be next.

"It seems like she's trying to see her play and probably face her. ... It's very good news for tennis." John McEnroe suggested Williams could compete in singles at Wimbledon, which starts June 28. "She's not getting any younger but

announced Monday that Williams has accepted a wild-card invitation to play doubles at next week's grass-court tournament in London.

Williams won seven Wimbledon titles and six at the US Open before stepping away from the game in 2022. In doubles, she won six titles at Wimbledon and two at the US Open — all with her older sister Venus Williams.

"She's a legend. It's inspiring to see," top-ranked Aryna Sabalenka said. "I'm excited to see her play and probably face her. ... It's very good news for tennis."

John McEnroe suggested Williams could compete in singles at Wimbledon, which starts June 28. "She's not getting any younger but



she's Serena Williams so I bet you she would tell me about wanting to win the whole damn thing," McEnroe said in Paris. The Queen's Club tournament starts next Monday and the WTA said Williams will play "with a partner to be announced in due

course." "Queen's Club feels like the perfect place to begin this next chapter," Williams said in a statement.

"Grass has given me some of the most meaningful moments of my career and I'm excited to be back competing on one of the sport's

most iconic stages."

Williams has not competed since bidding farewell at the 2022 US Open. At the time, Williams said she didn't want to use the word "retiring" and instead declared that she was "evolving" away from tennis.

Davenport said some current women's players went down to Florida to practice with Williams recently. "I don't think anyone's admitted to that, but I do know that some of them were," Davenport said. "So I think she has kind of a handle on where the level is. But I don't know if she's been playing a two-hour singles match, right? We'll have to see how she can handle that physically." (AP)

Praggnanandhaa, Gukesh, Divya keep India's title hopes alive with wins at Norway Chess title race

AJAI MASANO ■ Oslo

Indians struck back in style in Round 7 as D Gukesh and R Praggnanandhaa delivered crucial victories while Divya Deshmukh bounced back from her previous-round setback to beat compatriot Koneru Humpy, reigniting the country's challenge as the Norway Chess title race entered its decisive phase here.

World champion Gukesh salvaged 1.5 points from his clash against American Grandmaster Wesley So, securing victory in the Armageddon tie-break after letting a winning opportunity slip in the classical game, to move to eight points overall. He, however, remained



rooted to the bottom of the six-player double round-robin standings.

Praggnanandhaa, meanwhile, handed French Grandmaster Alireza Firouzja a second successive classical

defeat to collect the full three points and climb to nine, but the gains did little to alter the standings, with the young Indian GM remaining fifth and Gukesh sixth.

However, both Indians

stood within touching distance of the leaders and could yet make a late charge with three rounds still to be played. Wesley So continued to lead the standings with 12.5 points, while Alireza held second

place on 10. A tightly packed chasing group of three players — Praggnanandhaa, world No. 1 Magnus Carlsen and Germany's Vincent Keymer — shared third spot on nine points, keeping the title race wide open heading into the final three rounds.

Seven-time champion Carlsen, meanwhile, continued his resurgence after an inconsistent start, defeating Keymer in the Armageddon tie-break to stay firmly in contention.

Few would discount the Norwegian from the title race, given his proven ability to recover from early setbacks and mount late surges, a trait that has underpinned many of his triumphs over the years.

Gukesh, playing with the

white pieces, had worked his way into a winning position by activating his king and steadily pressing his advantage, but severe time trouble — with just 18 minutes remaining compared to So's hour on the clock — proved costly as the American defended well to force a draw in the classical game.

The world champion, however, made amends in the Armageddon tie-break, where the Indian displayed sharp calculation to seal victory with a courageous pawn grab on the queenside. Praggnanandhaa, also playing with the white pieces, seized the initiative by the 26th move when he won an extra pawn and gradually tightened his grip. (PTI)

GUKESH HAS THE EDGE IN EXPERIENCE OVER SINDAROV: NORWAY CHESS ARBITER

Anemone Kulczak, the chief arbiter at Norway Chess, has been a constant presence since the tournament's early days in 2013 — quietly observing its evolution, its innovations, and the shifting fortunes that have marked every edition.

A seasoned French arbiter with years of experience overseeing hundreds of elite clashes carries the authority that comes from long exposure to top-level chess events, and she is rarely quick to overstate conclusions. Even so, in her view, reigning world champion D Gukesh remains the clear favourite to defend his crown later this year.

"Javokhir Sindarov also has experience but as a world champion, you know, Gukesh has more experience, I would say. So, yes, for me he has more experience but the world championship games are really interesting to follow," says Kulczak, a mother of a young daughter who works in a biology lab in Nice, speaking in a strong French accent with a measured tone. Gukesh will take on Kazakhstan's Sindarov later this year to defend his title, with critics pointing to a dip in form since his 2024 world title triumph and suggesting he has not looked quite the same player.

ICC suspension unexpected, fixes under way: Cricket Canada

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Toronto

Cricket Canada has termed the ICC's decision to suspend its membership as "unexpected" and said it has initiated comprehensive corrective measures to address the governance and financial deficiencies flagged by the sport's global governing body.

The ICC, at its Board meeting in Ahmedabad on Sunday, suspended Cricket Canada with immediate effect for what it described as "serious breaches" of membership obligations. However, the world body clarified that Canadian national teams would continue

to remain eligible for ICC events to safeguard the interests of players.

Responding to the decision, Cricket Canada said it respected the ICC's ruling and remained committed to fulfilling all compliance requirements.

"The suspension was unexpected. Nevertheless, Cricket Canada respects the ICC's decision and is fully committed to meeting all compliance requirements. The Board has directed the Committee to accelerate its investigative and reform mandate to ensure that governance, financial oversight, and reporting systems are strengthened without delay," Cricket Canada said in a state-



ment to 'Sportsnet'. The governing body added that it has begun implementing remedial measures after receiving communication from the ICC.

"Since receiving ICC's notice, Cricket Canada has undertaken immediate, comprehensive, and structured corrective measures to remedy the governance, financial oversight, and administrative deficiencies identified in the ICC's correspondence," it said in the statement to the leading Canadian sports news organisation.

Cricket Canada also said it takes the concerns raised by the ICC seriously and remains focused on improving governance standards while supporting the growth of the

sport in the country. The suspension comes amid an ongoing ICC investigation into allegations of corruption involving Cricket Canada, which were highlighted in the CBC documentary 'Corruption, Crime and Cricket' earlier this year.

Cricket Canada maintained that it operates within the ICC's anti-corruption framework and remains compliant with applicable requirements of the apex body, while asserting that any findings would be based on verified facts and due process.

Canada is an associate member and participated in the T20 World Cup held in India earlier this year.

On Monday, while arriving

at the decision to suspend the associate nation, the ICC said in a statement, "In taking this decision, the ICC Board was mindful of the importance of protecting the interests of Canadian players and ensuring they are not disadvantaged by the governance issues affecting the national governing body.

"Accordingly, Canadian national representative teams will continue to be eligible to participate in ICC events during the period of suspension." The ICC will also provide Cricket Canada with a set of reinstatement conditions aimed at addressing the governance and administrative issues identified by the Board.



Atiqa Mir secures most dominant career win

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Thessaloniki (Greece)

Eleven-year-old Atiqa Mir reinforced her status as India's leading racer on the world stage with the most dominant performance of her career in Round 2 of the Champions of the Future Academy Program, making a clean sweep of qualifying, heat races and the finals.

Atiqa, the first Indian to be supported by the Formula 1 Academy, set the benchmark in a highly competitive field in the OK-NJ category (age 12-14). It is remarkable what she has managed to achieve in her first season in this category, giving the more experienced drivers (mostly male) a hard time on the track.

Be it the qualifying, heats or the two finals, Atiqa was in a league of her own throughout the weekend. With her sensational show, she became only the third driver to in the series' history to sweep the qualifying, heats and finals.

While she led with admirable poise and calm on track all through the week, the little girl in her

understandably got emotional when the Indian national anthem as she stood atop the podium. Atiqa is aiming to become the first female in Formula 1 since the early 1900s.

She won Round 2.2 by a more than 2.6 seconds, a massive margin in motorsport considering all 25 drivers were running on the same equipment.

Born in Mumbai with family roots in Jammu and Kashmir, Atiqa bagged the pole position in qualifying with a record time of 56.77, almost three tenths ahead of the second place driver, demonstrating skill well beyond her age and experience.

In Heat Race 1, Atiqa dominated the race from start to finish. In Heat Race 2, she bossed the field again, winning by more than a second ahead of her nearest competitor, putting her in P1 grid position for the final.

In the gruelling 15 lap final, Atiqa took control of the race at the start and demonstrated a racing masterclass, pulling away to a 3.9 seconds advantage in merely eight laps.

Atul Wassen sees shades of young Tendulkar in Vaibhav Sooryavanshi

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Former India pacer Atul Wassen sees shades of a young Sachin Tendulkar in Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, saying the teenager's maturity, audacity and fearless approach remind him of the batting great's early days during India's 1989 tour of Pakistan.

Sooryavanshi emerged as the breakout star of the recently concluded IPL season, topping the batting charts with 776 runs from 16 innings at an impressive strike rate of 237.30. The 15-year-old impressed with his fearless performances against some of the world's premier bowlers, including Jasprit Bumrah, Kagiso Rabada and Pat Cummins.



He is a one in a million generational talent. Can you imagine the maturity and audacity of this boy? He reminds me of 16-year-old Sachin Tendulkar.

"I saw Sachin and that game maturity and audacity to take the bull by the horns



(during the 1989 tour of Pakistan). God has blessed him with X factor along with the game & power," Wassen told PTI in an exclusive chat on Tuesday.

A 16-year-old Tendulkar had made his international debut against a fiery Pakistan

bowling attack that included Wasim Akram, Waqar Younis, Abdul Qadir and Imran Khan in 1989.

Tendulkar impressed everyone with his straight and on-drives. The grace and timing with which he struck those boundaries showed

he was a star in the making. "Though he has a long way to go. I hope everything falls into place just like it did for Sachin. The same God gifted X factor talent I see in Sooryavanshi."

Wassen stressed that Sooryavanshi's long-term development would depend on proper guidance and whether he is encouraged to become a "complete cricketer" rather than merely a T20 specialist.

"The only thing that bothers me is that is he being mentored enough to aspire for the Test cap? He is king of this format (T20). He has got the game. But does he have more talent than just hitting sixes?" Wassen said. The former Delhi captain warned against burdening

the teenager with expectations of record-breaking feats at such an early stage of his career. "It will be unfair to put the burden of breaking records. He should not be thinking or made to think about the records. He should aspire to become complete players like Tendulkar, Rahul Dravid and Virat Kohli.

"They took their game to a higher and higher level with longevity. There will be a time when you have to change your game.

"During challenging times, if he can go back to the basics and ethos of the game then he will emerge as a great player. So it all depends upon who all mentor him and how. Guys like (Anil) Kumble and Dravid can keep in good stead." (PTI)

Patidar to lead Gwalior Cheetahs in MPL 2026

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Gwalior

Having successfully led the Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) to back-to-back IPL crowns, Rajat Patidar is set to lead JKC Sports-owned Gwalior Cheetahs in the Madhya Pradesh League (MPL) T20.

Patidar will captain a side eager to make a breakthrough after reaching the semifinal in 2025 but narrowly missing out on a place in the final.

Gwalior Cheetahs will feature in the opening match of the 2026 season when they face Ujjain Falcons on Wednesday at the Holkar Stadium in Indore.



The Gwalior team will enter the new season with a balanced squad featuring a mix of experienced campaigners and promising young talent.

Among them is Mangesh Yadav, the leading wicket-taker from the 2025 edition with 14 wickets, while the side will continue to benefit from the

guidance of head coach Aditya Srivastava, under whose captaincy Madhya Pradesh ended a 69-year wait for the Ranji Trophy title in 2022.

FIH Women's Nations Cup: Lalthantluangi, Dabas earn maiden call-ups

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Young defenders Lalthantluangi and Shilpi Dabas will once again be a part of Salima Tete-led national team which will take part in the FIH Hockey Women's Nations Cup New Zealand scheduled to begin in Auckland from June 15 to 21.

India have been placed in Pool A of the tournament alongside Japan, United States and Uruguay, with Pool B comprising hosts New Zealand, Chile, Korea and France.

India will open their Nations Cup campaign against the United States on June 15, before facing Japan a day later. They will round off their pool stage with a clash against Uruguay on

Thursday, June 18. The semi-finals are scheduled for Saturday, June 20 and the final on June 21.

Tete will continue to lead the side for the tournament. Savita and Bichu Devi Khariabam will provide the team with reliable and experienced options for goal-keeping.

In defence, seasoned Sushila Chanu Pukhrabam, Ishika Chaudhary, Nikki Pradhan and Jyoti will be joined by Lalthantluangi and Dabas, both of whom earned their maiden senior call-ups during the recently concluded tour of Australia and will be eager to continue their development at this level.

The midfield will be marshalled by Salima, who will draw on the expertise of Neha, Sunelita Toppo and



Sakshi Rana around her.

They will be joined by Deepika Soreng, who also impressed during the friendly series in Australia.

In the forwardline, Navneet Kaur will be supported up front by Deepika, Rutuja Dadaso Pisal, Annu

and Ishika besides seasoned attacking midfielders Lalremisiami and Sonam.

Collectively they bring a blend of pace, creativity and clinical finishing to the forward line.

The Indian squad heads into the Nations Cup on the

back of a productive tour of Australia, where the side played a four-match friendly series in Perth in the lead-up to the FIH Hockey Women's Nations Cup New Zealand 2025-26.

The series provided the team with invaluable experience, giving Chief Coach Sjoerd Marijne an opportunity to test the squad. India held the hosts to a 2-2 draw in the series after four competitive matches.

Chief coach Sjoerd Marijne underlined the importance of the team's preparations ahead of a crucial phase, beginning with the Nations Cup, followed by the FIH World Cup and the Asian Games.

"The Nations Cup is an important tournament for us. We want to go there

and play with ambition to set a standard for ourselves that we can build on," Marijne said.

"We have built on those aspects in the Argentina and Australia tours, which gave us good preparation as a team. Now it is about taking the next step and showing that level consistently across a full tournament. The squad is motivated and ready for the challenge," he said.

Sharing his thoughts on the squad selection, the chief coach added, "We have named a squad that has the right balance of experience and hunger. Players like Savita, Sushila, Nikki and Navneet have been in big tournaments before and know what it takes to perform under pressure.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mullalpur

Jammu and Kashmir seamer Auqib Nabi Dar, whose non-selection in the Indian Test squad invited widespread criticism, has been summoned by the team management along with six others to bowl in the nets ahead of the one-off Test against Afghanistan starting June 6.

Besides Auqib, wiry UP leg-spinner Zeeshan Ansari, who plays for Sunrisers Hyderabad in the IPL, has also been asked to bowl in the nets as the Afghanistan team is expected to have a few wrist spinners.

"Yes Auqib Nabi has been asked to join the India nets. It is not just Auqib but there are six others, who have also been called to join the India nets. Due to extreme weather conditions, the two premier fast bowlers Mohammed Siraj and Prasidh Krishna can't go flat out in the nets after a gruelling three games in seven days with travel. The batters would need adequate practice," a BCCI source privy to the development told PTI.

Auqib, who got 60 wickets to become highest wicket-

taker while guiding Jammu and Kashmir to Ranji Trophy triumph, was piped by gangly Punjab paceman Gurnoor Brar in the Indian team.

The J&K medium pacer's omission had caused a furore with former India skipper and ex-chairman of selection committee Dilip Vengsarkar questioning the sanctity of Ranji Trophy if performances in the tournament weren't rewarded.

It is understood that Auqib hasn't yet been included in the 15-member squad but he is among the stand-bys.

Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna and Gurnoor Brar are three pacers in the 15 and only if one of the three has a niggles, will Auqib be included in the 15.

The Indian team will have its first practice session on Tuesday afternoon but all the players, who were part of the IPL final, are unlikely to train on the opening day.

For the record, seven Gujarat Titans players (skipper Shubman Gill, B Sai Sudharsan, Gurnoor Brar, Prasidh Krishna, Mohammed Siraj, Manav Suthar and Washington Sundar) are part of Test squad.

Indonesia Open: Sindhu advances to second round, Srikanth, Malvika exits

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jakarta

Two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu battled her way into the second round of the Indonesia Open with a straight-game win, while former world Number 1 Kidambi Srikanth suffered an opening-round exit on Tuesday.

Sindhu was made to work



hard by Thailand's Busanan Ongbamrungphan before prevailing 25-23, 21-16 in a 51-minute women's singles round of 32 contest of the Super 1,000 badminton tournament.

The former world champion displayed her trademark attacking game to edge a closely fought opening game before carrying the momentum into the second to complete a straight-game win.

National record holder KM Deeksha fails dope test

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Women's 1500m National record holder and National Games silver medallist K M Deeksha has failed a dope test, according to sources.

The 27-year-old Deeksha, who has participated in just one competition this year in April, has tested positive for a banned substance. The nature of the substance and further details of her test is not known.



"Yes, it's confirmed that she has failed a dope test," a well-placed source told PTI without elaborating on the matter. Deeksha did not take part in the recent Federation Cup in Ranchi

which was mandatory for an athlete to get selected for the 2026 Commonwealth Games (July 23 to August 2) in Glasgow, unless he or she is exempted by the Athletics Federation of India (AFI).

The AFI gave "eligible athletes" another chance to achieve CWG qualification standards in their respective events during the Ludhiana leg of the Indian Athletics Series scheduled for June 13. But the athletes should

have taken part in the Federation Cup for their performances in the Ludhiana event to be considered for CWG selection.

Deeksha, an athlete in the NADA's Registered Testing Pool, had clocked 4 minute 25.74 seconds to win the 1500m race at the Indian Open Athletics Series 2 in Jaipur on April 5. Her timing was also well outside the 4:05.09 seconds set by the AFI as qualifying standard for the CWG.